CURIOUS SPAROOWS · ENCYCLOPEDIC INDEX

BOOKS

The complete map of world literature, from palm leaves to e-books

Literatures of every language · poetry and prose · genres · history · movements · authors · awards · craft · ideas · reviews

Parts	Sections	Sub-sections	Entries	Register rows
11	41	153	530	133

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How to Use This Booklet

This booklet is a map of the whole world of books, from the oral epics and palm-leaf manuscripts to the e-book and the AI era. It is not a book's contents page: every entry tells you, in one or two lines, what the thing is and why it matters. A newcomer can learn the shape of literature just by turning the pages; a bookworm can check that nothing is missing.

Every entry has an ID (such as BOK-01.7 for Hindi literature). The same ID is the entry's address on curioussparoows.com, where each one is growing into its own page.

How this booklet is organised

Parts: the big branches: the intro questions, literatures of the world, forms and genres, history and movements, awards, craft and publishing, ideas, reviews, community, navigation and sources.

Sections (BOK-01 to BOK-27): the main topics, each opening with a *Before you start* box.

Sub-sections and entries (☐): one or two lines each; tick the box when you have read or explored it.

Book Registers: tables of landmark books for each region, and of award winners. They are a sourced selection; the full year-wise lists grow on the website.

How to explore it

Step 1. Read Part 0, ten two-minute questions that tell the story of the book.

Step 2. Find your own language in Part 1, then travel to another continent.

Step 3. Pick a form or genre you love in Part 2 and follow its examples.

Step 4. Use the tags (#hindi, #haiku, #nobel) and See also links to jump between pages.

Step 5. Tick ☐ as you go, and use the tracker at the end.

Our promise

Knowledge belongs to the people who created it. Every fact here stands on a source listed in Part 10, and every "latest" fact says when it was checked. Where something could not be verified, we say so instead of guessing. Found a mistake? Tell us, and we will fix it and thank you.

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PART 0 — THE INTRODUCTION TWIG: HOW CAN MARKS ON A PAGE PUT ANOTHER MIND INSIDE YOURS?

About this Part. This is the doorway to the whole Books section of the website. It follows the tree-twig format of the Curious Sparoows library: one Gateway page, ten Leaves and one Recap. Each Leaf answers one question in about two minutes (250 to 400 words). It gives the short answer at the top and ends with an honest hook to the next question. A "Full journey" page on the website shows every Leaf on one page.

BOK-00 The Gateway: How can a few marks on a page put another person's mind inside yours?

Web address: /books/how-books-work/ · **Keywords:** history of books for beginners, why we read, how writing began, what is literature

Open any book and something strange happens. Black marks on paper turn into a voice in your head. That voice may belong to someone who died two thousand years ago, or who lives on the other side of the world, and for a few hours you think their thoughts.

This short course follows one question in ten small steps: **how did humans learn to store minds on a page, and why do we still do it?** It goes from storytellers who carried epics in memory, through palm leaves, printing presses and novels, to e-books and AI. Each page takes about two minutes and hands you the next question. You can stop after any page and still leave with a complete answer.

By the end you will be able to:

- Tell the story of the book in order, from memory to clay to paper to screen.
- Explain why India wrote on palm leaves and birch bark, and why so many texts were memorised.
- Say how printing changed religion, science and politics.
- Explain, with real research, what reading does to the brain.
- Think clearly about whether e-books and AI will replace books.

BOK-00.01 How did humans tell stories before writing?

> **Short answer:** With memory, rhythm and community. For most of human history, literature was oral: epics, songs, riddles and laws were memorised and performed. Rhyme, metre and repetition were the "storage technology".

Keywords: oral tradition, oral literature, how the Vedas were preserved, bards, storytelling before writing

The oldest library was a human head

Writing is only about 5,000 years old, but people have told stories for as long as they have had language. Before writing, a story survived only if someone remembered it and someone else wanted to hear it. So stories were shaped to be remembered: they used **rhythm, rhyme, refrains, stock phrases and vivid images**.

India's extraordinary memory

India is the world's great example. The **Vedas** were composed from roughly 1500 BCE and passed down orally for centuries before they were written. Reciters used patterns such as **padapatha** (word by word), **kramapatha** and **ghanapatha**, which repeat words in different orders like an error-checking code. UNESCO recognised Vedic chanting as an Intangible Cultural Heritage of Humanity in 2008 (proclaimed 2003).

Bards everywhere

Greek bards sang the Homeric epics. West African **griots** (jeli) still carry the history of families and kingdoms, including the *Epic of Sundiata*. In Rajasthan, **bhopas** sing the epic of Pabuji in front of a painted phad scroll. Tribal communities across India, from the Gonds to the Bhils, keep creation stories and songs in memory.

What oral literature does well

Oral stories change a little with every telling. They belong to the community rather than to one author. They are performed, not just read, so music, gesture and audience all matter.

Remember this: Literature is older than writing; memory and rhythm were the first books.

Next: If stories lived in memory, who first wrote one down, and what was the first "book"?

BOK-00.02 Who wrote the first book?

Short answer: Writing began in Mesopotamia (cuneiform, around 3300–3100 BCE) and Egypt (hieroglyphs) for accounts and records. Among the oldest literary works are the Sumerian hymns of **Enheduanna** (around 2300 BCE), often called the first named author, and the **Epic of Gilgamesh**.

Keywords: first book ever written, oldest literature, Epic of Gilgamesh, Enheduanna, history of writing

Writing began with accounts, not poems

The first writing in Sumer recorded grain, sheep and debts on clay tablets. Writing was invented independently in a few places: Mesopotamia, Egypt, China (oracle-bone script, around 1200 BCE) and Mesoamerica. The Indus script (around 2600–1900 BCE) is still undeciphered, so we do not know what it says.

The first named author

Enheduanna, a priestess and daughter of King Sargon of Akkad, wrote hymns to the goddess Inanna around 2300 BCE. She is usually called the first author known by name, and she was a woman.

The first great story

The **Epic of Gilgamesh** tells of a king who loses his friend Enkidu and searches for immortality. Its stories circulated from around 2100 BCE, and the best-known version was found in the library of King Ashurbanipal at Nineveh (7th century BCE). It even contains a flood story.

What counts as a "book"?

A clay tablet is not a book as we know it. Over time, writing moved to **papyrus scrolls** (Egypt), **bamboo and silk** (China), **palm leaves and birch bark** (India), **parchment** and finally the **codex**, the bound book with pages, which spread in the Roman world from the 1st century CE.

Remember this: The first writing was bookkeeping; the first named author was a woman poet, Enheduanna.

Next: India did not use clay. Why did it write on palm leaves?

BOK-00.03 Why did India write on palm leaves?

Short answer: Because palm leaves were cheap, plentiful and durable in the Indian climate. Scribes wrote on dried talipot or palmyra leaves, and on birch bark (bhojpatra) in the north. Leaves were tied with string through holes; the word **grantha** (book) comes from "tying".

Keywords: palm leaf manuscripts, bhojpatra, how ancient Indian books were made, grantha meaning, National Mission for Manuscripts

Making a palm-leaf book

Leaves were dried, boiled, smoothed and cut to size. In the south and east, scribes **scratched** letters with an iron stylus and rubbed in soot or lamp-black so the grooves turned black; this helped shape rounded scripts like Odia and

Malayalam, because straight lines would split the leaf. In the north, people often **wrote with ink** on birch bark or palm leaf.

The Gilgit and Bakhshali manuscripts

The **Gilgit manuscripts** (birch bark, about the 5th–7th centuries CE) are among the oldest surviving manuscripts in India and include Buddhist texts. The **Bakhshali manuscript** of mathematics, also on birch bark, contains a dot used as zero; radiocarbon tests in 2017 dated some of its leaves to the 3rd–4th century CE, though scholars still debate its exact age.

A living heritage

Leaves decay, so texts were copied again and again by families, monasteries, temples and Jain **bhandars** (libraries) such as those at Patan and Jaisalmer. India's **National Mission for Manuscripts** (2003) estimates that India holds millions of manuscripts, many still uncatalogued.

Paper arrives

Paper, invented in China (traditionally credited to Cai Lun, 105 CE), reached India through Central Asia and was common by the Sultanate and Mughal periods. Mughal workshops produced illustrated manuscripts such as the *Hamzanama*.

> **Remember this:** India's "books" were tied bundles of leaves, copied again and again, and its scripts were shaped by the stylus.
>
> **Next:** Copying by hand was slow. How did printing change the world?

BOK-00.04 How did printing change the world?

> **Short answer:** Printing made copies cheap and identical. China printed first (woodblock; the *Diamond Sutra* of 868 CE is the oldest dated printed book). Bi Sheng made movable type around 1040. **Johannes Gutenberg's** press (around 1450) spread across Europe and helped power the Reformation, the Scientific Revolution and newspapers.

Keywords: history of printing, Gutenberg press, Diamond Sutra, first printing press in India, movable type

Asia first

The **Diamond Sutra** found at Dunhuang is dated 868 CE. **Bi Sheng** made clay movable type in Song China, and Korea printed the *Jikji* with metal movable type in 1377, before Gutenberg.

Gutenberg's revolution

Around 1450 in Mainz, Gutenberg combined metal type, oil-based ink and a screw press. His **Bible** appeared about 1455. Within fifty years, presses were running in more than 200 European cities, and millions of books had been printed. Martin Luther's pamphlets of 1517 spread fast because of print.

Printing reaches India

Portuguese Jesuits set up a press in **Goa in 1556**. The first book printed in an Indian script was Tamil: *Thambiran Vanakkam* (1578). In 1800 the **Serampore Mission Press** (William Carey) and Fort William College began printing in Bengali, Hindi and many other languages. Newspapers followed: *Hicky's Bengal Gazette* (1780).

What changed

Ideas could now travel faster than rulers could stop them. Spelling and languages became more standard. Readers could compare identical copies, which helped science. It also made censorship a bigger business.

> **Remember this:** Printing turned books from rare treasures into everyday tools, first in Asia, then explosively in Europe.
>
> **Next:** Once books were cheap, a new form appeared that worried parents and priests. Why was the novel once called dangerous?

BOK-00.05 Why was the novel once called dangerous?

> **Short answer:** Because it let ordinary readers, especially young women, live other lives in private. In 18th- and 19th-century Europe and India, critics warned that novels corrupted morals and wasted time. The same fear later attached to comics, television, video games and phones.

Keywords: history of the novel, first novel ever, Tale of Genji, Don Quixote, first Indian novel

Where the novel began

There is no single first novel. **Murasaki Shikibu's** *The Tale of Genji* (Japan, around 1010) is often called the world's first novel. **Cervantes's** *Don Quixote* (1605 and 1615) is called the first modern European novel. Sanskrit had long prose romances: **Banabhatta's** *Kadambari* (7th century), whose name became the word for "novel" in Kannada and Marathi.

The fear of novels

In 18th-century England, sermons and newspapers warned that novels made girls dreamy and disobedient. In 19th-century Bengal and Maharashtra, reformers argued about whether novels taught good conduct or bad.

India's first novels

Bengali's *__Durgeshnandini__* (Bankim Chandra Chattopadhyay, 1865) is often called the first major Indian novel. Earlier candidates include *Alaler Gharer Dulal* (Peary Chand Mitra, 1857) in Bengali, *Pariksha Guru* (Lala Srinivas Das, 1882) in Hindi, *Indulekha* (O. Chandu Menon, 1889) in Malayalam and *Rajmohan's Wife* (Bankim, 1864) in English.

Why the fear was wrong, and right

Novels did change people. They taught readers to imagine the inner life of someone else, which researchers today link to empathy (BOK-21). That is exactly why rulers and moralists feared them.

> **Remember this:** The novel is a machine for living other lives, and every new storytelling machine is feared at first.

Next: Is poetry older than all of this?

BOK-00.06 Is poetry older than prose?

> **Short answer:** In literature, yes, almost everywhere. The oldest literary works (the Vedas, Gilgamesh, Homer, the Chinese *Shijing*, Tamil Sangam poems) are in verse, because rhythm helps memory. Prose literature grows later, once writing is common.

Keywords: oldest poetry, why poetry came first, chhanda, metre in poetry, Shijing

Why verse came first

Verse is easier to remember. A line with a fixed beat tells you when you have forgotten a syllable. India built a full science of metre, **chhandas**, one of the six Vedangas; **Pingala's** *Chandahshastra* (before 200 BCE) even uses binary-like patterns of short and long syllables.

Verse for everything

Ancient India wrote medicine, astronomy and grammar in verse. Aryabhata's astronomy (499 CE) is in verse. The Chinese *Shijing* (Classic of Poetry) collects songs from around 1000 to 600 BCE. **Tamil Sangam** poetry (roughly 300 BCE to 300 CE) sorts poems into **akam** (inner life, love) and **puram** (outer life, war and kings).

Then prose grows up

Prose appears in law codes, commentaries, letters, histories and stories. Sanskrit prose romances, Greek history (Herodotus), Chinese history (Sima Qian) and Arabic prose all grow once writing is common.

Today

Prose dominates bookshops, but poetry survives everywhere people want words to be remembered: songs, slogans, prayers, film lyrics, rap and Instagram poems.

Remember this: Poetry came first because rhythm was memory; prose came when paper did the remembering.

Next: Some of these old poems outlived the kingdoms that made them. Why do some books outlive empires?

BOK-00.07 Why do some books outlive empires?

Short answer: Because they are copied, taught, translated and loved by many communities for different reasons. A "classic" survives when each generation finds something new in it. Luck, religion, schools and translation all help.

Keywords: what makes a classic, oldest books still read, why classics survive, Panchatantra translations

The Panchatantra's journey

The **Panchatantra** (animal fables, compiled perhaps around 300 CE) was translated into Middle Persian in the 6th century, then into Arabic as *Kalila wa Dimna* (Ibn al-Muqaffa, 8th century), then into Hebrew, Latin and most European languages. It is one of the most translated books in history.

The four reasons books survive

1. **Copying communities**: monasteries, temples, madrasas, families and later schools kept copying.
2. **Rereadability**: the *Mahabharata*, Homer and Shakespeare say different things to different ages.
3. **Translation**: a book in many languages is hard to destroy.
4. **Luck**: fire, war and decay destroyed much. The Library of Alexandria's losses and the burning of Nalanda (around 1193) are remembered as warnings.

What we lost

Most ancient literature is lost. We know of hundreds of Greek plays by title only. Many Sanskrit, Tamil and Prakrit works survive only as quotations in other books.

Remember this: A classic is a book that every generation chooses to copy again.

Next: Classics survive in libraries, but what actually happens in your brain when you read one?

BOK-00.08 What happens in your brain when you read?

Short answer: Reading borrows brain circuits built for vision and speech. A small region on the left side, nicknamed the "letterbox area" by the neuroscientist Stanislas Dehaene, learns to recognise written words. Stories also activate areas used for understanding other people's minds.

Keywords: reading and the brain, Stanislas Dehaene, Maryanne Wolf, deep reading, how children learn to read

The brain was not built to read

Writing is too recent for evolution to have made a reading organ. Instead, as Dehaene explains in *Reading in the Brain* (2009), a child's brain **recycles** part of the visual system (the visual word form area) to recognise letters and link them to sounds.

Deep reading

The scholar **Maryanne Wolf** (*Proust and the Squid*, 2007; *Reader, Come Home*, 2018) describes "deep reading": slow, attentive reading that builds inference, analogy and empathy. She worries that skimming on screens trains a shallower habit, though research on this is still developing.

Stories and other minds

Psychologists **Keith Oatley** and **Raymond Mar** have found links between reading fiction and the ability to understand others' feelings, though how strong the effect is remains debated (BOK-21).

Reading in many scripts

Readers of Hindi (an abugida), Chinese (logographic) and English (alphabetic) use slightly different brain strategies. Learning to read in any script changes the brain.

Remember this: Reading is a cultural invention that rewires a natural brain, and it trains us to imagine other minds.

Next: If reading is so powerful, will e-books, audiobooks and AI replace books?

BOK-00.09 Will e-books and AI replace books?

Short answer: Unlikely. They are adding new ways to read, as printing did. E-books, audiobooks and web novels have grown, but printed books still sell strongly worldwide. AI can write text, but books are also about trust, authorship and shared culture, which raises new questions of credit and copyright.

Keywords: future of books, e-books vs print, audiobooks, AI written books, web novels

Every new medium was meant to kill the book

Radio, cinema, television and the internet were each expected to end reading. Instead, books changed shape.

The digital shelf

Michael Hart started **Project Gutenberg** in 1971, the first digital library. Amazon's **Kindle** (2007) made e-books mainstream. **Audiobooks** have grown fast. **Web novels** and platforms such as Wattpad, China's web-fiction sites and India's Pratilipi (many Indian languages) have created millions of new readers and writers.

AI and the book

AI tools can now draft text, translate and summarise. This raises real questions: who is the author, who gets credited, and was the AI trained on writers' work without permission? Courts and publishers are still deciding. Curious Sparoows labels AI-assisted work openly, which is one honest answer.

What a book still does

A book offers a whole, finished argument or world, by a responsible author, that you can return to. That deep, unbroken attention is hard to replace.

Remember this: The book keeps changing its body: tablet, scroll, codex, screen, voice. It has not lost its soul.

Next: Let's put the whole story together.

BOK-00.10 Recap: the story of the book in one page

Short answer: Humans told stories in memory, wrote them on clay, leaves and scrolls, printed them, turned them into novels and now read them on screens and hear them as audio. The constant is one mind reaching another.

Keywords: history of books summary, story of literature, books timeline

1. **Memory** (forever): oral epics, songs and the Vedas.
2. **Writing** (from about 3300 BCE): Sumer, Egypt, China, Mesoamerica.
3. **First authors**: Enheduanna, Gilgamesh, Homer, Sangam poets, Valmiki and Vyasa (by tradition).
4. **Leaves, scrolls and codices**: palm leaf and birch bark in India, papyrus in Egypt, the codex in Rome.
5. **Paper and print**: China (105 CE paper; 868 Diamond Sutra), Korea (1377 Jikji), Gutenberg (about 1455), Goa (1556), Serampore (1800).
6. **The novel**: Genji (around 1010), Don Quixote (1605), Durgeshnandini (1865).
7. **Mass reading**: cheap paperbacks (Penguin, 1935), libraries and literacy campaigns.

8. **Digital**: Project Gutenberg (1971), Kindle (2007), audiobooks, web novels, AI.

Remember this: Every book is a conversation across time; you are the latest person invited.

Next: Start exploring the literatures of the world in Part 1, beginning with India.

PART 1 — LITERATURES OF THE WORLD

About this Part. The first great classification is where and in what language a book was written. It begins with India in full depth (classical languages, every Eighth Schedule language, major regional languages, tribal oral literatures and Indian writing in English), then travels continent by continent. Each literature has an identity card (script, oldest works, golden ages, signature forms), its masters, and a **Book Register** of landmark works. **The registers are a curated landmark selection, not a complete list.** See "How the registers grow" (BOK-05.6).

Register fields. Year · Title (original, with English meaning) · Author · Form · Awards and adaptations · Why it matters. Dates of ancient works are scholarly estimates. A dash (—) means not recorded here, never a guess. Film adaptations link to the Movies index (MOV-).

BOK-01 Indian literatures: one civilisation, many tongues

Before you start — BOK-01. India has 22 languages in the Eighth Schedule of the Constitution, six languages declared "classical" by 2014 (Tamil, Sanskrit, Kannada, Telugu, Malayalam, Odia) and five more added in October 2024 (Marathi, Pali, Prakrit, Assamese, Bengali), and hundreds of mother tongues. Sahitya Akademi recognises 24 languages for its awards (the 22 plus English and Rajasthani). Indian literature is therefore not one literature but a family that shares epics, bhakti poets and modern themes. **See also:** BOK-12 History of the book, BOK-16.1 Indian awards, MOV-01 Indian cinema (adaptations).

☐ BOK-01.1 Sanskrit literature

The classical language of ancient India, with literature from the Vedas (from about 1500 BCE) to the present day. Written in many scripts, today mostly Devanagari. **Tags:** #sanskrit #classical #india

- ☐ **Vedic literature**: the four Vedas (Rig, Sama, Yajur, Atharva), then Brahmanas, Aranyakas and Upanishads, the philosophical heart of the tradition.
- ☐ **Itihasa (the epics)**: the *Ramayana* (by tradition Valmiki, the "adi kavi", first poet) and the *Mahabharata* (by tradition Vyasa), which contains the *Bhagavad Gita*.
- ☐ **Puranas**: eighteen major Puranas of myth, genealogy and devotion, such as the *Bhagavata Purana*.
- ☐ **Kavya (court poetry)**: Ashvaghosha (*Buddhacharita*), Kalidasa (*Raghuvamsha*, *Kumarasambhava*, *Meghaduta*), Bharavi, Magha, Sriharsha; the five great kavyas (pancha mahakavya).
- ☐ **Drama (nataka)**: Bhasa, Kalidasa (*Abhijnanashakuntalam*), Shudraka (*Mrichchhakatika*), Vishakhadatta (*Mudrarakshasa*), Bhavabhuti (*Uttararamacharita*).
- ☐ **Prose and story**: Banabhatta (*Kadambari*, *Harshacharita*), Dandin (*Dashakumaracharita*), the *Panchatantra*, *Hitopadesha*, *Kathasaritsagara* (Somadeva), *Vetala Panchavimshati*.
- ☐ **Lyric and devotion**: Bhartrihari's *Shatakatraya*, Jayadeva's *Gita Govinda* (12th century), Amaru's *Amarushataka*.
- ☐ **Shastra (knowledge texts)**: Panini's grammar *Ashtadhyayi*, Bharata's *Natyashastra*, Kautilya's *Arthashastra*, Charaka and Sushruta (medicine), Aryabhata (astronomy), Kalhana's *Rajatarangini* (history of Kashmir, 1148–49).
- ☐ **Modern Sanskrit**: writers still publish; Sahitya Akademi gives an annual Sanskrit award.

☐ BOK-01.2 Pali and Prakrit literatures

Languages of early Buddhism and Jainism, declared classical in 2024. **Tags:** #pali #prakrit #buddhist #jain

- ☐ **Pali Canon (Tipitaka)**: Vinaya, Sutta and Abhidhamma; the *Dhammapada* and *Jataka* tales (stories of the Buddha's past lives).
- ☐ **Jain Agamas**: in Ardhamagadhi Prakrit; later commentaries.
- ☐ **Prakrit poetry**: Hala's *Gaha Sattasai* (Maharashtri Prakrit, early centuries CE), seven hundred love poems of village life.
- ☐ **Apabhramsha**: the bridge to modern North Indian languages; Svayambhu's Ramayana (*Paumachariu*), Pushpadanta.

☐ BOK-01.3 Tamil literature

India's oldest continuous classical literature after Sanskrit, the first language declared classical (2004). **Tags:** #tamil #classical #sangam

- ☐ **Sangam literature** (about 300 BCE–300 CE): the Eight Anthologies (*Ettuthokai*) and Ten Idylls (*Pattuppattu*), sorted into akam (love) and puram (war, public life); *Tolkappiyam*, the oldest grammar.
- ☐ **Ethical works**: Thiruvalluvar's *Thirukkural*, 1,330 couplets on virtue, wealth and love, translated into dozens of languages.
- ☐ **Twin epics**: *Silappatikaram* (Ilango Adigal) and *Manimekalai* (Sattanar).
- ☐ **Bhakti**: the Shaiva Nayanars (*Tevaram*) and Vaishnava Alvars (*Nalayira Divya Prabandham*), including Andal, from the 6th–9th centuries.
- ☐ **Kamban's* Ramavataram*** (12th century): the great Tamil Ramayana.
- ☐ **Modern**: Subramania Bharati (poet of freedom), Pudhumaippithan (short story), Kalki (*Ponniyin Selvan*), Jayakanthan, Sujatha, Ashokamitran, Ambai, Bama (*Karukku*, Dalit memoir), Perumal Murugan, Imayam, Salma, Vairamuthu.

☐ BOK-01.4 Kannada literature

Classical language (2008); eight Kannada writers have won the Jnanpith Award. **Tags:** #kannada #classical

- ☐ **Early**: *Kavirajamarga* (9th century, earliest surviving work on poetics); Pampa, Ponna and Ranna, the "three gems" of Jain Kannada poetry.
- ☐ **Vachana movement** (12th century): Basavanna, Akka Mahadevi, Allama Prabhu; short prose poems against caste and ritual.
- ☐ **Haridasa songs**: Purandara Dasa and Kanaka Dasa.
- ☐ **Modern**: Kuvempu (first Kannada Jnanpith, 1967), D. R. Bendre, Shivaram Karanth, Masti Venkatesha Iyengar, V. K. Gokak, U. R. Ananthamurthy (*Samskara*), Girish Karnad (drama), Chandrashekhara Kambara, S. L. Bhyrappa, Devanur Mahadeva, Vivek Shanbhag, Banu Mushtaq (International Booker 2025).

☐ BOK-01.5 Telugu literature

Classical language (2008); famous for its musical verse and avadhanam memory feats. **Tags:** #telugu #classical

- ☐ **Kavitrayam**: Nannaya, Tikkana and Errapragada, who rendered the *Mahabharata* in Telugu (11th–14th centuries).
- ☐ **Prabandha age**: Krishnadevaraya's court, the Ashtadiggajas; Allasani Peddana; Tenali Ramakrishna of the folk tales.
- ☐ **Saints and singers**: Vemana (pithy verses), Annamacharya, Tyagaraja (Carnatic songs), Pothana (*Bhagavatam*).
- ☐ **Modern**: Gurajada Apparao (*Kanyasulkam*, 1892 play), Viswanatha Satyanarayana (first Telugu Jnanpith), Sri Sri (*Maha Prasthanam*), C. Narayana Reddy, Ravuri Bharadwaja, Chalam, Volga.

☐ BOK-01.6 Malayalam literature

Classical language (2013) with one of India's highest reading cultures. **Tags:** #malayalam #classical #kerala

- ☐ **Early**: *Ramacharitam*, the Manipravalam style (Malayalam mixed with Sanskrit); Cherusseri's *Krishnagatha*.
- ☐ **Thunchaththu Ezhuthachan** (16th century): "father of modern Malayalam", *Adhyatma Ramayanam*.
- ☐ **Modern poets**: the triumvirate Kumaran Asan, Ulloor and Vallathol; G. Sankara Kurup (first Jnanpith ever, 1965, for *Odakkuzhal*).
- ☐ **Novel**: O. Chandu Menon's *Indulekha* (1889), Thakazhi Sivasankara Pillai (*Chemmeen*), Vaikom Muhammad Basheer, S. K. Pottekkatt, M. T. Vasudevan Nair, O. V. Vijayan (*Khasakkinte Itihasam*), Kamala Das (Madhavikutty), M. Mukundan, Benyamin (*Aadujeevitham*), K. R. Meera.

☐ BOK-01.7 Hindi literature

The literature of India's most widely spoken language, with roots in Braj, Awadhi and Khari Boli. **Tags:** #hindi

- ☐ **Adikal / Veergatha** (about 1000–1350): heroic ballads such as *Prithviraj Raso* (attributed to Chand Bardai; date debated).
- ☐ **Bhakti kal** (about 1350–1650): Kabir and the nirgun saints; Surdas (Braj, Krishna); Tulsidas (*Ramcharitmanas*, Awadhi, 1574 onward); Malik Muhammad Jayasi (*Padmavat*, 1540); Meera's songs; Raskhan, Rahim.
- ☐ **Riti kal** (about 1650–1850): ornate court poetry: Keshavdas, Bihari (*Satsai*), Bhushan, Ghananand.

- ☐ **Adhunik kal** (modern, from about 1850): Bharatendu Harishchandra, Mahavir Prasad Dwivedi; Chhayavad poets Jaishankar Prasad (*Kamayani*), Suryakant Tripathi "Nirala", Sumitranandan Pant, Mahadevi Verma.
- ☐ **Fiction**: Premchand (*Godaan*, 1936; short stories), Phanishwar Nath Renu (*Maila Anchal*), Yashpal, Jainendra, Agyeya, Bhisham Sahni (*Tamas*), Nirmal Verma, Mohan Rakesh, Mannu Bhandari, Krishna Sobti, Shrilal Shukla (*Raag Darbari*), Manohar Shyam Joshi, Vinod Kumar Shukla, Geetanjali Shree (*Ret Samadhi*, International Booker 2022 as *Tomb of Sand*, tr. Daisy Rockwell).
- ☐ **Poetry after 1947**: Nayi Kavita, Muktibodh, Raghuvir Sahay, Dhumil, Kedarnath Singh, Kunwar Narayan, Harivansh Rai Bachchan (*Madhushala*), Ramdhari Singh "Dinkar", Dushyant Kumar (Hindi ghazal).
- ☐ **Dalit and women's writing**: Omprakash Valmiki (*Joothan*), Mamta Kalia, Maitreyi Pushpa, Chitra Mudgal.

☐ BOK-01.8 Urdu literature

Born in the Deccan and Delhi from Persian, Arabic and Indian roots; the great language of the ghazal. **Tags:** #urdu #ghazal

- ☐ **Dakhni beginnings**: Quli Qutb Shah, Wali Dakhni.
- ☐ **Classical ghazal**: Mir Taqi Mir, Sauda, Ghalib (letters and ghazals), Momin, Zauq, Dagh.
- ☐ **Reform and nazm**: Hali, Nazir Akbarabadi (poet of everyday life), Muhammad Iqbal, Josh Malihabadi.
- ☐ **Progressive Writers' Movement** (founded 1936, first conference presided by Premchand): Faiz Ahmad Faiz, Sahir Ludhianvi, Kaifi Azmi, Ali Sardar Jafri, Majrooh Sultanpuri.
- ☐ **Fiction**: Saadat Hasan Manto (*Toba Tek Singh*), Ismat Chughtai (*Lihaaf*), Krishan Chander, Rajinder Singh Bedi, Qurratulain Hyder (*Aag ka Darya*; Jnanpith 1989), Intizar Husain, Shamsur Rahman Faruqi.
- ☐ **Dastangoi**: the art of long oral tales such as the *Dastan-e Amir Hamza*, revived in Delhi from 2005.

☐ BOK-01.9 Bengali literature

Classical language (2024); the first Indian literature to win the Nobel Prize (Tagore, 1913). **Tags:** #bengali #bangla

- ☐ **Charyapada** (about 8th–12th centuries): Buddhist songs, the earliest Bengali (and Assamese and Odia) writing.
- ☐ **Medieval**: Chandidas, *Mangal kavya* narratives, Krittivas's Ramayana, Chaitanya biographies.
- ☐ **Bengal Renaissance**: Ishwar Chandra Vidyasagar (prose), Michael Madhusudan Dutt (*Meghnad Badh Kavya*, blank verse), Bankim Chandra (*Anandamath* with "Vande Mataram").
- ☐ **Rabindranath Tagore**: *Gitanjali*, *Gora*, *Ghare Baire*, short stories, songs (Rabindrasangeet), two national anthems (India and Bangladesh).
- ☐ **After Tagore**: Sarat Chandra (*Devdas*), Kazi Nazrul Islam (the "rebel poet"), Jibanananda Das, Bibhutibhushan Bandyopadhyay (*Pather Panchali*), Tarashankar, Manik Bandyopadhyay, Mahasweta Devi, Sunil Gangopadhyay, Shirshendu, Satyajit Ray (Feluda), Humayun Ahmed and Taslima Nasrin (Bangladesh).

☐ BOK-01.10 Marathi literature

Classical language (2024); strong traditions of saint poetry, theatre and Dalit autobiography. **Tags:** #marathi

- ☐ **Saints (Varkari tradition)**: Dnyaneshwar (*Dnyaneshwari*, 1290), Namdev, Eknath, Tukaram (abhangas), Janabai, Bahinabai.
- ☐ **Powada and lavani**: heroic ballads and folk song.
- ☐ **Modern**: Hari Narayan Apte, V. S. Khandekar (*Yayati*; Jnanpith 1974), Kusumagraj, P. L. Deshpande (humour), Vinda Karandikar, Bhalchandra Nemade (*Kosla*), Durga Bhagwat, G. A. Kulkarni.
- ☐ **Dalit literature**: Namdeo Dhasal (Dalit Panthers, 1972), Daya Pawar (*Baluta*), Laxman Mane, Sharankumar Limbale, Urmila Pawar.
- ☐ **Theatre**: Vijay Tendulkar (*Ghashiram Kotwal*), Mahesh Elkunchwar.

☐ BOK-01.11 Gujarati literature

Tags: #gujarati

- ☐ **Early**: Hemachandra's grammar (12th century); Narsinh Mehta (15th century, "Vaishnava Jana To"), Akho, Premanand (akhyana storytelling).

☐ **Modern**: Narmad, Govardhanram Tripathi (*Saraswatichandra*), Mahatma Gandhi's autobiography (*Satya na Prayogo*, 1925–29), K. M. Munshi, Umashankar Joshi (Jnanpith 1967, shared), Pannalal Patel, Raghuveer Chaudhari.

☐ BOK-01.12 Punjabi literature

Written in Gurmukhi (India) and Shahmukhi (Pakistan). **Tags:** #punjabi

☐ **Baba Farid** (12th–13th century) and the **Guru Granth Sahib** (compiled 1604, with verses of the Sikh Gurus and saints of many faiths).

☐ **Sufi poets**: Bulleh Shah, Shah Hussain, Sultan Bahu; Waris Shah's *Heer* (1766).

☐ **Modern**: Bhai Vir Singh, Amrita Pritam (*Pinjar*; "Ajj aakhaan Waris Shah nu" on Partition), Shiv Kumar Batalvi, Gurdial Singh, Surjit Patar, Pash.

☐ BOK-01.13 Odia literature

Classical language (2014). **Tags:** #odia

☐ **Sarala Das's Mahabharata** (15th century); the **Panchasakha** saint-poets; Upendra Bhanja (ornate kavya).

☐ **Modern**: Fakir Mohan Senapati (*Chha Mana Atha Guntha*, 1897, a pioneering realist novel), Gopinath Mohanty (Jnanpith 1973), Sitakant Mahapatra, Pratibha Ray.

☐ BOK-01.14 Assamese literature

Classical language (2024). **Tags:** #assamese

☐ **Madhava Kandali's Ramayana** (14th century), among the first in a modern Indian language.

☐ **Srimanta Sankardev** (15th–16th century): borgeet songs, ankiya naat plays, the Sattriya tradition.

☐ **Modern**: Lakshminath Bezbarua, Birendra Kumar Bhattacharya (Jnanpith 1979), Mamoni Raisom Goswami (Indira Goswami), Nilmani Phookan.

☐ BOK-01.15 Other Eighth Schedule literatures

☐ **Kashmiri**: Lal Ded (Lalleshwari, 14th century vakhs), Habba Khatoon, Mahjoor, Rahman Rahi (Jnanpith 2004).

☐ **Konkani**: Shenoy Goembab, Ravindra Kelekar (Jnanpith 2006), Damodar Mauzo (Jnanpith 2022).

☐ **Maithili**: Vidyapati (14th–15th century love songs), Harimohan Jha, Nagarjuna (Yatri).

☐ **Manipuri (Meiteilon)**: the *Cheitharol Kumbaba* royal chronicle, Hijam Anganghal, Lamabam Kamal.

☐ **Nepali**: Bhanubhakta Acharya (Nepali Ramayana), Laxmi Prasad Devkota (*Muna Madan*), Indra Bahadur Rai (Darjeeling).

☐ **Sindhi**: Shah Abdul Latif Bhittai (*Shah Jo Risalo*), Sachal Sarmast; writers in India after Partition such as Moti Prakash.

☐ **Santali**: written in the Ol Chiki script created by Pandit Raghunath Murmu (1925); oral creation stories.

☐ **Dogri**: Padma Sachdev, Dinoo Bhai Pant.

☐ **Bodo**: hymns, folk literature and modern poetry in the Devanagari script.

☐ BOK-01.16 Rajasthani, Bhojpuri, Awadhi, Braj and other languages

☐ **Rajasthani** (recognised by Sahitya Akademi): Dingal and Pingal bardic poetry, *Dhola Maru*, Meera's songs, *Veli Krishan Rukmani ri* (Prithviraj Rathore), Vijaydan Detha ("Bijji", folk tales, *Duvidha*), Kanhaiyalal Sethia, Chandra Prakash Deval.

☐ **Bhojpuri**: Bhikhari Thakur (*Bidesiya*, "the Shakespeare of Bhojpuri"), folk songs of migration.

☐ **Awadhi and Braj**: the bhakti classics of Tulsidas and Surdas.

☐ **Tulu, Kodava, Garhwali, Kumaoni, Chhattisgarhi, Haryanvi** and others: oral epics, songs and modern writing.

☐ BOK-01.17 Tribal and oral literatures of India

☐ Creation myths, songs and epics of the Gond (*Pandvani*-style performances), Bhil (*Bhilodi Mahabharata*), Santal, Munda, Oraon, Khasi, Mizo, Naga and Toda peoples.

☐ Collectors and champions: Verrier Elwin, Ganesh Devy (People's Linguistic Survey of India, Bhasha Research Centre), Ramnika Gupta.

☐ Modern Adivasi writers: Hansda Sowvendra Shekhar, Temsula Ao, Mamang Dai, Jacinta Kerketta, Narayan (Malayalam, *Kocharethi*).

☐ BOK-01.18 Indian writing in English

☐ **Pioneers**: Henry Derozio, Toru Dutt, Bankim's *Rajmohan's Wife* (1864), Sarojini Naidu, Sri Aurobindo (*Savitri*), Tagore's own translations.

☐ **The founding trio**: Mulk Raj Anand (*Untouchable*, 1935), R. K. Narayan (Malgudi), Raja Rao (*Kanthapura*, 1938).

☐ **Midnight's children**: Salman Rushdie (*Midnight's Children*, Booker 1981), Vikram Seth (*A Suitable Boy*), Amitav Ghosh (Jnanpith 2018, first English-language writer to win it), Arundhati Roy (*The God of Small Things*, Booker 1997), Anita Desai, Kiran Desai (Booker 2006), Rohinton Mistry, Upamanyu Chatterjee, Aravind Adiga (Booker 2008), Jhumpa Lahiri (Pulitzer 2000).

☐ **Poets**: Nissim Ezekiel, A. K. Ramanujan, Kamala Das, Dom Moraes, Jayanta Mahapatra, Arun Kolatkar (*Jejuri*), Eunice de Souza, Jeet Thayil.

☐ **Popular fiction**: Ruskin Bond, Chetan Bhagat, Amish Tripathi, Anuja Chauhan, Ashwin Sanghi.

☐ **Translation as Indian literature**: A. K. Ramanujan, Arshia Sattar, Daisy Rockwell, Deepa Bhasthi, Arunava Sinha and others make the bhasha literatures available across India and the world.

Book Register — India (landmark selection)

Year	Title	Author	Form and language	Awards and adaptations	Why it matters
c. 1500–1000 BCE	Rig Veda	Many rishis	Hymns, Vedic Sanskrit	UNESCO Memory of the World (2007, manuscripts in Pune)	Oldest Indian text; preserved orally
c. 400 BCE–400 CE	Mahabharata	Vyasa (by tradition)	Epic, Sanskrit	Countless films and TV (B. R. Chopra series, 1988)	One of the longest poems in the world; contains the Gita
c. 500–100 BCE	Ramayana	Valmiki (by tradition)	Epic, Sanskrit	Ramanand Sagar series (1987)	Retold in every Indian and many Asian languages
c. 300 BCE–300 CE	Sangam anthologies	Many poets	Poems, Tamil	—	Akam–puram poetics; oldest Tamil literature
c. 4th–5th c. CE	Abhijnanashakuntalam	Kalidasa	Drama, Sanskrit	Translated by William Jones (1789); admired by Goethe	Introduced Sanskrit literature to Europe
c. 300–500 CE	Thirukkural	Thiruvalluvar	Couplets, Tamil	Translated into many languages	Universal ethics in 1,330 couplets
c. 300 CE	Panchatantra	Vishnu Sharma (by tradition)	Fables, Sanskrit	Became *Kalila wa Dimna*	Among the most translated books ever
1290	Dnyaneshwari	Dnyaneshwar	Gita commentary, Marathi	—	Founding work of Marathi literature
1574 onward	Ramcharitmanas	Tulsidas	Epic, Awadhi	UNESCO Memory of the World Asia-Pacific (2024, illustrated manuscripts)	The most read Ramayana in North India
15th c.	Kabir's verses (Bijak and others)	Kabir	Dohas and songs	Sung across faiths	Voice against caste and ritual
1865	Durgeshnandini	Bankim Chandra Chattopadhyay	Novel, Bengali	—	Often called the first major Indian novel
1889	Indulekha	O. Chandu Menon	Novel, Malayalam	—	First major Malayalam novel
1910 / 1912	Gitanjali / Song Offerings	Rabindranath Tagore	Poems, Bengali and English	Nobel Prize 1913	First Nobel for a non-European
1917	Devdas	Sarat Chandra Chattopadhyay	Novel, Bengali	Many films (1935, 1955, 2002)	Most filmed Indian novel
1929	Pather Panchali	Bibhutibhushan	Novel, Bengali	Satyajit Ray film (1955)	Village childhood, world

		Bandyopadhyay			classic
1935	Untouchable	Mulk Raj Anand	Novel, English	Preface by E. M. Forster	Founding Indian English novel of protest
1936	Godaan	Premchand	Novel, Hindi	Film (1963)	Peak of Hindi realist fiction
1936	Kamayani	Jaishankar Prasad	Epic poem, Hindi	—	Masterpiece of Chhayavad
1947	Toba Tek Singh	Saadat Hasan Manto	Short story, Urdu	Films and plays	Partition's madness in a few pages
1954	Maila Anchal	Phanishwar Nath Renu	Novel, Hindi	TV serial	Founded the "anchalik" regional novel
1956	Chemmeen	Thakazhi Sivasankara Pillai	Novel, Malayalam	Film (1965), first South Indian President's Gold Medal	Fisherfolk love and taboo
1959	Aag ka Darya	Qurratulain Hyder	Novel, Urdu	—	2,500 years of Indian history in one novel
1965	Samskara	U. R. Ananthamurthy	Novel, Kannada	Film (1970)	Caste and conscience; translated by A. K. Ramanujan
1968	Raag Darbari	Shrilal Shukla	Satire, Hindi	Sahitya Akademi 1969	India's sharpest satire of village politics
1969	Khasakkinte Itihasam	O. V. Vijayan	Novel, Malayalam	—	Changed the Malayalam novel
1981	Midnight's Children	Salman Rushdie	Novel, English	Booker 1981; "Booker of Bookers" 1993 and "Best of the Booker" 2008	Made Indian English fiction global
1992	Karukku	Bama	Memoir, Tamil	Crossword Award (English tr., 2000)	First Dalit woman's autobiography in Tamil
1993	A Suitable Boy	Vikram Seth	Novel, English	BBC series (2020)	One of the longest single-volume English novels
1997	The God of Small Things	Arundhati Roy	Novel, English	Booker 1997	First Booker for an Indian woman citizen
2008	Aadujeevitham (Goat Days)	Benyamin	Novel, Malayalam	Film *Aadujeevitham* (2024)	Migrant worker's story; huge Kerala bestseller
2018	Ret Samadhi (Tomb of Sand)	Geetanjali Shree	Novel, Hindi	International Booker 2022 (tr. Daisy Rockwell)	First Indian-language book to win it
2025	Heart Lamp	Banu Mushtaq	Short stories, Kannada	International Booker 2025 (tr. Deepa Bhasthi)	First short-story collection to win it

BOK-02 Literatures of Asia

Before you start — BOK-02. Asia holds the oldest written literatures after Mesopotamia and Egypt, and several of the world's great classical traditions: Chinese, Persian, Arabic, Japanese. Many share forms across borders: the ghazal travelled from Arabic to Persian, Urdu and now English; the Ramayana travelled across South-East Asia. **See also:** BOK-01 India, BOK-06 Poetry forms, MOV-04 Asian cinema.

☐ BOK-02.1 Chinese literature

☐ **Classics**: the *Shijing* (Classic of Poetry), Confucius's *Analects*, the *Daodejing* (attributed to Laozi), *Zhuangzi*, Sima Qian's *Records of the Grand Historian* (about 94 BCE).

☐ **Tang poetry** (618–907): Li Bai, Du Fu, Wang Wei, Bai Juyi, the golden age of Chinese verse; Song ci lyrics (Su Shi, Li Qingzhao).

☐ **The Four Great Classical Novels**: *Romance of the Three Kingdoms*, *Water Margin*, *Journey to the West* (Wu Cheng'en; the Monkey King, based on the monk Xuanzang's real journey to India) and *Dream of the Red Chamber* (Cao Xueqin, 18th century).

☐ **Modern**: Lu Xun ("A Madman's Diary", 1918; *The True Story of Ah Q*), Lao She, Ba Jin, Eileen Chang, Mo Yan (Nobel 2012), Gao Xingjian (Nobel 2000, French citizen), Yu Hua, Can Xue, Liu Cixin (*The Three-Body Problem*; Hugo Award 2015), Jin Yong (wuxia novels).

☐ BOK-02.2 Japanese literature

☐ **Classical**: the *Kojiki* (712) and *Man'yōshū* poetry anthology (8th century); Murasaki Shikibu's *The Tale of Genji* (about 1010); Sei Shōnagon's *The Pillow Book*; *The Tale of the Heike*.

☐ **Forms**: waka and tanka, renga, haiku (Matsuo Bashō, Buson, Issa, Shiki), noh and kabuki drama, Chikamatsu's puppet plays.

☐ **Modern**: Natsume Sōseki (*Kokoro*), Ryūnosuke Akutagawa ("Rashōmon"), Yasunari Kawabata (Nobel 1968), Yukio Mishima, Kenzaburō Ōe (Nobel 1994), Haruki Murakami, Banana Yoshimoto, Yoko Ogawa, Sayaka Murata, Kazuo Ishiguro (British, born in Japan; Nobel 2017).

☐ **Manga and light novels**: see BOK-10.9.

☐ BOK-02.3 Korean literature

☐ **Classical**: hyangga and sijo poetry; the *Samguk yusa*; *The Tale of Chunhyang* (pansori story); the Hangul alphabet created under King Sejong (promulgated 1446) made literacy easy.

☐ **Modern**: Yi Sang, Pak Kyongni (*Land*), Ko Un, Shin Kyung-sook (*Please Look After Mom*), Han Kang (*The Vegetarian*, International Booker 2016 with translator Deborah Smith; Nobel Prize 2024, the first Korean and first Asian woman laureate), Cho Nam-joo (*Kim Jiyoung, Born 1982*), webtoons.

☐ BOK-02.4 Persian literature

☐ **Epic**: Ferdowsi's *Shahnameh* (completed 1010), the national epic of Iran, about 50,000 couplets.

☐ **Mystical and lyric masters**: Rumi (*Masnavi*), Hafez (ghazals; consulted for omens in Iranian homes), Saadi (*Gulistan*, *Bustan*), Attar (*The Conference of the Birds*), Omar Khayyam (*Rubaiyat*, made famous in English by Edward FitzGerald, 1859), Nizami (*Layla and Majnun*).

☐ **India's Persian**: Amir Khusrau, Bedil, Ghalib's Persian works; Persian was a court language of India for centuries.

☐ **Modern**: Sadegh Hedayat (*The Blind Owl*), Forugh Farrokhzad, Simin Daneshvar, Shahrnush Parsipur.

☐ BOK-02.5 Arabic literature

☐ **Pre-Islamic poetry**: the *Mu'allaqat* (the "hanging odes"), qasida form.

☐ **The Qur'an** (7th century) as the supreme model of Arabic prose and rhyme (see BOK-11).

☐ **Classical**: al-Mutanabbi, Abu Nuwas, al-Jahiz; the *Maqamat* of al-Hariri; *One Thousand and One Nights* (stories gathered from Indian, Persian and Arab sources; Scheherazade); Ibn Battuta's travels; Ibn Khaldun's *Muqaddimah* (1377).

☐ **Andalusia**: Ibn Hazm (*The Ring of the Dove*), Ibn Arabi, Ibn Rushd.

☐ **Modern (Nahda and after)**: Naguib Mahfouz (Cairo Trilogy; Nobel 1988), Taha Hussein, Mahmoud Darwish, Nizar Qabbani, Adonis, Tayeb Salih (*Season of Migration to the North*), Ghassan Kanafani, Jokha Alharthi (*Celestial Bodies*, International Booker 2019).

☐ BOK-02.6 Turkish and Central Asian literature

☐ **Turkic epics**: the *Book of Dede Korkut*; *Manas* (Kyrgyz, one of the longest epics); Yunus Emre's Sufi poems.

☐ **Ottoman divan poetry**: Fuzuli, Baki, Nedim.

☐ **Modern Turkish**: Nazım Hikmet, Yaşar Kemal (*Memed, My Hawk*), Orhan Pamuk (Nobel 2006; *My Name Is Red*), Elif Şafak.

☐ **Central Asia**: Alisher Navoi (Chagatai), Chinghiz Aitmatov (Kyrgyz).

☐ BOK-02.7 South and South-East Asian neighbours

☐ **Pakistan**: Faiz, Manto, Intizar Husain, Bapsi Sidhwa, Mohammed Hanif, Kamila Shamsie (Women's Prize 2018).

☐ **Bangladesh**: Kazi Nazrul Islam (national poet), Jasimuddin, Humayun Ahmed, Selina Hossain.

☐ **Sri Lanka**: Sinhala classics; Martin Wickramasinghe; Michael Ondaatje (*The English Patient*, Booker 1992), Shehan Karunatilaka (Booker 2022).

☐ **Nepal**: Bhanubhakta, Devkota, Parijat.

☐ **Myanmar, Thailand, Cambodia, Laos**: Ramayana retellings (Thai *Ramakien*, Khmer *Reamker*), Thai poet Sunthorn Phu.

☐ **Indonesia and Malaysia**: wayang stories, *Hikayat*, Pramoedya Ananta Toer (*Buru Quartet*), Chairil Anwar, Eka Kurniawan.

☐ **Vietnam**: Nguyễn Du's *The Tale of Kiều* (national poem), Bảo Ninh (*The Sorrow of War*).

☐ **Philippines**: José Rizal (*Noli Me Tángere*, 1887), Nick Joaquín, F. Sionil José.

☐ BOK-02.8 Hebrew and Jewish literatures

☐ The Hebrew Bible (Tanakh; see BOK-11), Talmud, medieval poets (Yehuda Halevi), Yiddish literature (Sholem Aleichem, Isaac Bashevis Singer, Nobel 1978), modern Hebrew (S. Y. Agnon, Nobel 1966; Amos Oz; David Grossman, International Booker 2017).

Book Register — Asia (landmark selection)

Year	Title	Author	Form and country	Awards and adaptations	Why it matters
c. 2100–1200 BCE	Epic of Gilgamesh	Anonymous	Epic, Mesopotamia (Iraq)	—	Oldest surviving great story
c. 1000–600 BCE	Shijing	Anonymous (compiled by tradition by Confucius)	Poems, China	—	Root of Chinese poetry
c. 4th c. BCE	Daodejing	Laozi (attributed)	Philosophy, China	Among the most translated books	Taoism's founding text
c. 1010	The Tale of Genji	Murasaki Shikibu	Novel, Japan	Films, manga	Often called the first novel
1010	Shahnameh	Ferdowsi	Epic, Iran	—	Preserved Persian language and myth
9th–14th c.	One Thousand and One Nights	Many tellers	Frame tales, Arab world	Countless films (Aladdin)	World's favourite story collection
13th c.	Masnavi	Jalaluddin Rumi	Mystical poem, Persian	—	Among the most read poets today
14th c.	Romance of the Three Kingdoms	Luo Guanzhong (attributed)	Novel, China	Games, TV, films	Strategy and loyalty classic
16th c.	Journey to the West	Wu Cheng'en (attributed)	Novel, China	Many films; Dragon Ball	Monkey King; the road to India
1694	Oku no Hosomichi (Narrow Road to the Deep North)	Matsuo Bashō	Travel and haiku, Japan	—	Model of the haiku journey
1791	Dream of the Red Chamber	Cao Xueqin	Novel, China	TV (1987)	Peak of the Chinese novel
1820	The Tale of Kiều	Nguyễn Du	Verse novel, Vietnam	—	Vietnam's national poem
1887	Noli Me Tángere	José Rizal	Novel, Philippines	—	Inspired Philippine independence
1914	Kokoro	Natsume Sōseki	Novel, Japan	Films	Loneliness in a changing Japan
1921	The True Story of Ah Q	Lu Xun	Novella, China	—	Founded modern Chinese fiction
1956–57	Cairo Trilogy	Naguib Mahfouz	Novels, Egypt	Nobel Prize 1988	Family saga of modern Egypt
1966	Season of Migration to the North	Tayeb Salih	Novel, Sudan	—	Arab postcolonial classic
1987	Norwegian Wood	Haruki Murakami	Novel, Japan	Film (2010)	Made Murakami a global phenomenon
1998	My Name Is Red	Orhan Pamuk	Novel, Turkey	Nobel 2006 to the author	Art, murder and East–West
2006	The Three-Body Problem	Liu Cixin	Science fiction, China	Hugo 2015; Netflix series (2024)	First Asian Hugo winner for novel

2007	The Vegetarian	Han Kang	Novel, South Korea	International Booker 2016; author Nobel 2024	Korean literature's global moment
2010	Celestial Bodies	Jokha Alharthi	Novel, Oman	International Booker 2019 (tr. Marilyn Booth)	First Arabic winner
2020 / 2024	Taiwan Travelogue	Yang Shuang-zi	Novel, Taiwan	International Booker 2026 (tr. Lin King)	First Taiwanese author and translator to win

BOK-03 Literatures of Europe

Before you start — BOK-03. Europe's literatures grew from Greek and Latin roots, the Bible, medieval epics and the printing press. National literatures rose with national languages from the 1300s. **See also:** BOK-13 Literary movements, MOV-03 European cinema.

☐ BOK-03.1 Ancient Greek and Latin

☐ **Greek**: Homer (*Iliad*, *Odyssey*), Hesiod, Sappho (lyric), Aesop (fables), the tragedians Aeschylus, Sophocles (*Oedipus the King*) and Euripides, the comic Aristophanes, historians Herodotus and Thucydides, philosophers Plato and Aristotle (*Poetics*).

☐ **Latin**: Virgil (*Aeneid*), Ovid (*Metamorphoses*), Horace, Catullus, Cicero, Seneca, Augustine (*Confessions*).

☐ BOK-03.2 English literature (Britain and Ireland)

☐ **Old and Middle English**: *Beowulf*, Chaucer (*The Canterbury Tales*, about 1387–1400), *Sir Gawain and the Green Knight*.

☐ **Renaissance**: Shakespeare (37 to 39 plays and 154 sonnets), Marlowe, Spenser, Donne, the King James Bible (1611), Milton (*Paradise Lost*, 1667).

☐ **18th century and the rise of the novel**: Defoe (*Robinson Crusoe*, 1719), Swift (*Gulliver's Travels*), Richardson, Fielding, Samuel Johnson's *Dictionary* (1755).

☐ **Romantics**: Blake, Wordsworth, Coleridge, Byron, Shelley, Keats, Mary Shelley (*Frankenstein*, 1818).

☐ **Victorians**: Jane Austen (just before, 1811–1817), the Brontës, Dickens, George Eliot (*Middlemarch*), Thomas Hardy, Lewis Carroll, Tennyson, Browning.

☐ **Modernists and after**: Joseph Conrad, Virginia Woolf, James Joyce (*Ulysses*, 1922), T. S. Eliot, W. B. Yeats (Nobel 1923), George Orwell, Samuel Beckett (Nobel 1969), Doris Lessing, Seamus Heaney, Hilary Mantel, Zadie Smith, Sally Rooney.

☐ BOK-03.3 French literature

☐ *The Song of Roland*; Rabelais; Montaigne (invented the essay, 1580); Molière, Racine, Corneille; Voltaire (*Candide*), Rousseau; Victor Hugo (*Les Misérables*), Balzac, Flaubert (*Madame Bovary*), Zola, Baudelaire (*Les Fleurs du mal*), Rimbaud; Proust (*In Search of Lost Time*), Colette; Sartre, Camus (*The Stranger*), Simone de Beauvoir; the nouveau roman; Annie Ernaux (Nobel 2022); Francophone writers from Africa, the Caribbean and Quebec.

☐ BOK-03.4 German-language literature

☐ *Nibelungenlied*; Luther's Bible; Goethe (*Faust*), Schiller; the Brothers Grimm (folk tales, 1812); Heine; Thomas Mann (*Buddenbrooks*; Nobel 1929), Rilke, Kafka (*The Metamorphosis*), Hermann Hesse (*Siddhartha*, 1922; Nobel 1946), Brecht, Günter Grass, W. G. Sebald, Herta Müller, Jenny Erpenbeck (International Booker 2024).

☐ BOK-03.5 Russian literature

☐ Pushkin (*Eugene Onegin*), Gogol, Lermontov; the great novelists Tolstoy (*War and Peace*, *Anna Karenina*) and Dostoevsky (*Crime and Punishment*, *The Brothers Karamazov*); Turgenev; Chekhov (stories and plays); Gorky; Akhmatova, Tsvetaeva, Mandelstam, Pasternak (*Doctor Zhivago*; Nobel 1958), Bulgakov (*The Master and Margarita*), Solzhenitsyn (Nobel 1970), Nabokov.

☐ **Tolstoy and India**: Tolstoy's *A Letter to a Hindu* (1908) and letters with Gandhi influenced non-violent resistance.

☐ BOK-03.6 Spanish, Portuguese and Italian literatures

☐ **Spain**: *El Cantar de mio Cid*, Cervantes (*Don Quixote*), Lope de Vega, Calderón, Lorca, the Generation of '27, Carmen Laforet, Javier Marías.

☐ **Portugal**: Camões (*The Lusiads*, 1572, about Vasco da Gama's voyage to India), Fernando Pessoa (his heteronyms), José Saramago (Nobel 1998).

☐ **Italy**: Dante (*Divine Comedy*, early 1300s), Petrarch (sonnet), Boccaccio (*Decameron*), Ariosto, Machiavelli; Manzoni (*The Betrothed*); Pirandello, Italo Calvino, Primo Levi, Umberto Eco (*The Name of the Rose*), Elena Ferrante.

☐ BOK-03.7 Nordic, Central and Eastern European literatures

☐ **Icelandic sagas** and the *Eddas* (13th century); Ibsen and Strindberg (drama); Hans Christian Andersen (fairy tales); Selma Lagerlöf (first woman Nobel in literature, 1909); Knut Hamsun; Astrid Lindgren (*Pippi Longstocking*); Tove Jansson (Moomins); Jon Fosse (Nobel 2023); Nordic noir crime.

☐ **Central and Eastern Europe**: Kafka and Hašek (Czech), Milan Kundera, Wisława Szymborska and Olga Tokarczuk (Polish Nobels 1996 and 2018), Ivo Andrić (Yugoslav Nobel 1961), Imre Kertész and László Krasznahorkai (Hungarian Nobels 2002 and 2025), Georgi Gospodinov (Bulgaria, International Booker 2023), Taras Shevchenko and Lesya Ukrainka (Ukraine).

Book Register — Europe (landmark selection)

Year	Title	Author	Form and country	Awards and adaptations	Why it matters
c. 8th c. BCE	Iliad and Odyssey	Homer (tradition)	Epics, Greece	Countless	Foundation of Western literature
29–19 BCE	Aeneid	Virgil	Epic, Rome	—	Rome's national epic
c. 1308–1321	Divine Comedy	Dante Alighieri	Epic poem, Italy	—	Shaped the Italian language
c. 1387–1400	The Canterbury Tales	Geoffrey Chaucer	Verse tales, England	—	Made English a literary language
1605 / 1615	Don Quixote	Miguel de Cervantes	Novel, Spain	Many films and musicals	First modern European novel
c. 1600	Hamlet	William Shakespeare	Tragedy, England	Endless films, incl. *Haider* (2014)	Most performed and quoted play
1813	Pride and Prejudice	Jane Austen	Novel, England	BBC (1995), films, *Bride and Prejudice* (2004)	Model of the romantic and social novel
1818	Frankenstein	Mary Shelley	Novel, England	Films from 1910	Founding work of science fiction
1862	Les Misérables	Victor Hugo	Novel, France	Musical (1980), films	Justice, mercy and revolution
1866	Crime and Punishment	Fyodor Dostoevsky	Novel, Russia	Films; *Phir Subah Hogi* (1958)	The psychological novel
1869	War and Peace	Leo Tolstoy	Novel, Russia	Films (1956, 1966–67)	Often called the greatest novel
1915	The Metamorphosis	Franz Kafka	Novella, Prague (German)	—	Gave the world the word "Kafkaesque"
1922	Ulysses	James Joyce	Novel, Ireland	—	Modernist landmark
1922	Siddhartha	Hermann Hesse	Novel, Germany	Film (1972, shot in India)	Brought Indian spirituality to Western readers
1949	Nineteen Eighty-Four	George Orwell (born in Motihari, Bihar)	Novel, England	Films (1956, 1984)	"Big Brother", "doublethink"
2012–2015	Neapolitan Novels	Elena Ferrante	Novels, Italy	HBO series	A pen-named global phenomenon
2023	Prophet Song	Paul Lynch	Novel, Ireland	Booker 2023	Dystopia of a family in collapse
2025	Flesh	David Szalay	Novel, UK (Hungarian-British author)	Booker 2025	Latest Booker winner when checked (3 Nov 2026)

BOK-04 Literatures of the Americas

Before you start — BOK-04. The Americas combine Indigenous oral and written traditions (the Maya *Popol Vuh*), the colonial languages (English, Spanish, Portuguese, French) and African diaspora traditions. **See also:** MOV-02 Cinemas of the Americas.

☐ BOK-04.1 Indigenous literatures

☐ The K'iche' Maya *Popol Vuh* (written down in the 16th century), Aztec (Nahuatl) poetry of Nezahualcóyotl, Inca oral traditions, North American Native storytelling; modern writers N. Scott Momaday (Pulitzer 1969), Louise Erdrich (Pulitzer 2021), Joy Harjo (US Poet Laureate 2019–2022), Tommy Orange.

☐ BOK-04.2 Literature of the United States

☐ **19th century**: Washington Irving, Poe (inventor of the detective story, "The Murders in the Rue Morgue", 1841), Hawthorne, Melville (*Moby-Dick*, 1851), Emerson and Thoreau (*Walden*; influenced Gandhi's civil disobedience), Walt Whitman (*Leaves of Grass*), Emily Dickinson, Harriet Beecher Stowe, Mark Twain (*Huckleberry Finn*), Frederick Douglass's narrative.

☐ **20th century**: Henry James, Edith Wharton, Jack London, F. Scott Fitzgerald (*The Great Gatsby*), Hemingway, Faulkner, John Steinbeck, the Harlem Renaissance (Langston Hughes, Zora Neale Hurston), Richard Wright, Ralph Ellison, James Baldwin, Harper Lee, the Beats, Sylvia Plath, Kurt Vonnegut, Philip Roth, Toni Morrison (Nobel 1993), Maya Angelou, Cormac McCarthy, Bob Dylan (Nobel 2016, as songwriter), Louise Glück (Nobel 2020).

☐ **Today**: Colson Whitehead, Jhumpa Lahiri, Ocean Vuong, Percival Everett (*James*, Pulitzer 2025), Daniel Kraus (*Angel Down*, Pulitzer 2026).

☐ BOK-04.3 Canada

☐ L. M. Montgomery (*Anne of Green Gables*), Margaret Atwood (*The Handmaid's Tale*; Booker 2000 and 2019), Alice Munro (Nobel 2013), Michael Ondaatje, Rohinton Mistry and M. G. Vassanji (Indian and South Asian diaspora), Yann Martel (*Life of Pi*, Booker 2002, set in Pondicherry), Anne Carson (poet, classicist; Nobel Prize 2026), French-Canadian (Québécois) literature.

☐ BOK-04.4 Latin America

☐ **Colonial and early**: Sor Juana Inés de la Cruz (Mexico, 17th century).

☐ **Modernismo**: Rubén Darío (Nicaragua), José Martí (Cuba).

☐ **The great poets**: Gabriela Mistral (Chile; first Latin American Nobel, 1945), Pablo Neruda (Chile, Nobel 1971), César Vallejo (Peru), Octavio Paz (Mexico, Nobel 1990; ambassador to India 1962–1968, wrote *In Light of India*).

☐ **The Boom (1960s–70s)**: Gabriel García Márquez (Colombia; *One Hundred Years of Solitude*; Nobel 1982), Julio Cortázar, Carlos Fuentes, Mario Vargas Llosa (Peru, Nobel 2010).

☐ **Also**: Jorge Luis Borges (Argentina, *Ficciones*), Juan Rulfo (*Pedro Páramo*), Isabel Allende, Roberto Bolaño, Mariana Enríquez.

☐ **Brazil (Portuguese)**: Machado de Assis, Jorge Amado, Clarice Lispector, Paulo Coelho (*The Alchemist*, among the most translated books by a living author).

☐ BOK-04.5 The Caribbean

☐ Aimé Césaire and the Négritude movement (Martinique), Derek Walcott (St Lucia, Nobel 1992; *Omeros*), V. S. Naipaul (Trinidad, of Indian descent; Nobel 2001; *A House for Mr Biswas*), Jean Rhys (*Wide Sargasso Sea*), Jamaica Kincaid, Marlon James (Jamaica; Booker 2015), Edwidge Danticat (Haiti), Indo-Caribbean writing of the girmitiya descendants.

Book Register — The Americas (landmark selection)

Year	Title	Author	Form and country	Awards and adaptations	Why it matters
16th c. (oral	Popol Vuh	K'iche' Maya	Sacred narrative, Guatemala	—	Masterpiece of Indigenous American literature

older)					
1851	Moby-Dick	Herman Melville	Novel, USA	Films (1956)	Obsession, the sea and the sublime
1854	Walden	Henry David Thoreau	Essays, USA	—	Simple living; read by Gandhi
1855	Leaves of Grass	Walt Whitman	Poems, USA	—	Free verse democracy
1884	Adventures of Huckleberry Finn	Mark Twain	Novel, USA	Many films	Hemingway: all modern American literature comes from it
1925	The Great Gatsby	F. Scott Fitzgerald	Novel, USA	Films (1974, 2013)	The American dream questioned
1944	Ficciones	Jorge Luis Borges	Stories, Argentina	—	Labyrinths, libraries and infinity
1955	Pedro Páramo	Juan Rulfo	Novel, Mexico	Netflix film (2024)	Inspired magical realism
1960	To Kill a Mockingbird	Harper Lee	Novel, USA	Pulitzer 1961; film (1962)	Justice and race through a child's eyes
1961	A House for Mr Biswas	V. S. Naipaul	Novel, Trinidad	—	Indo-Caribbean life
1967	One Hundred Years of Solitude	Gabriel García Márquez	Novel, Colombia	Netflix series (2024)	Defining work of magical realism
1985	The Handmaid's Tale	Margaret Atwood	Novel, Canada	TV series (2017)	Dystopia of control over women
1987	Beloved	Toni Morrison	Novel, USA	Pulitzer 1988; film (1998)	Memory of slavery
1988	The Alchemist (O Alquimista)	Paulo Coelho	Fable, Brazil	—	Global bestseller; Guinness record for translations of a living author's book (2009)
2001	Life of Pi	Yann Martel	Novel, Canada	Booker 2002; Ang Lee film (2012)	Faith and survival, starting in Pondicherry
2024	James	Percival Everett	Novel, USA	Pulitzer 2025; National Book Award 2024	Huckleberry Finn retold by Jim
2025	Angel Down	Daniel Kraus	Novel, USA	Pulitzer Prize for Fiction 2026	A war novel written as one long sentence

BOK-05 Literatures of Africa and Oceania

Before you start — BOK-05. Africa has the world's richest living oral literatures and some of the oldest written ones (Egyptian, Ge'ez in Ethiopia, Swahili in Arabic script, the Timbuktu manuscripts). Modern African literature is written in English, French, Portuguese, Arabic and African languages (Yoruba, Gikuyu, Swahili, Zulu, Amharic). Oceania includes Aboriginal Australian, Māori and Pacific traditions. **See also:** MOV-05 Africa and Oceania.

☐ BOK-05.1 Ancient Egypt and Ethiopia

☐ Egyptian *Book of the Dead*, *The Tale of Sinuhe*, love songs; the Ethiopian *Kebra Nagast* (14th century, Ge'ez).

☐ BOK-05.2 West and Central Africa

☐ **Oral epics**: *Sundiata* (Mali), the griot tradition, Yoruba ifá poetry.

☐ **Timbuktu manuscripts**: hundreds of thousands of Arabic and Ajami manuscripts on law, astronomy and poetry.

☐ **Modern**: Chinua Achebe (*Things Fall Apart*, 1958), Wole Soyinka (Nobel 1986, first African laureate), Amos Tutuola, Buchi Emecheta, Ben Okri (Booker 1991), Chimamanda Ngozi Adichie, Ama Ata Aidoo (Ghana), Léopold Sédar Senghor and Mariama Bâ (Senegal), Ahmadou Kourouma.

☐ BOK-05.3 East and Southern Africa

☐ Swahili poetry (utenzi), Ngũgĩ wa Thiong'o (who switched from English to Gikuyu; *Decolonising the Mind*, 1986), Abdulrazak Gurnah (Tanzania/UK, Nobel 2021), Nadine Gordimer (South Africa, Nobel 1991), J. M. Coetzee (Booker 1983

and 1999; Nobel 2003), Damon Galgut (Booker 2021), Alan Paton (*Cry, the Beloved Country*), Zakes Mda; Gandhi's *Indian Opinion* newspaper and *Hind Swaraj* (1909) were written in South Africa.

☐ BOK-05.4 North Africa and the Maghreb

☐ Ibn Khaldun, Naguib Mahfouz (see BOK-02.5), Assia Djebar, Kateb Yacine, Tahar Ben Jelloun, Kamel Daoud (Prix Goncourt 2024).

☐ BOK-05.5 Australia, New Zealand and the Pacific

☐ Aboriginal songlines (the world's oldest continuous storytelling cultures), Māori whakapapa and oral literature; Patrick White (Nobel 1973), Peter Carey and Richard Flanagan (Booker), Kate Grenville, Les Murray, Alexis Wright (Waanyi; Miles Franklin 2007 and 2024), Katherine Mansfield, Janet Frame, Keri Hulme (*The Bone People*, Booker 1985), Witi Ihimaera (*The Whale Rider*), Albert Wendt (Samoa).

Book Register — Africa and Oceania (landmark selection)

Year	Title	Author	Form and country	Awards and adaptations	Why it matters
c. 1900 BCE	The Tale of Sinuhe	Anonymous	Story, Egypt	—	Among the oldest prose narratives
13th c. (oral)	Epic of Sundiata	Griots of Mali	Oral epic	Still performed by griots	Founding of the Mali Empire
1948	Cry, the Beloved Country	Alan Paton	Novel, South Africa	Films	Apartheid's eve
1958	Things Fall Apart	Chinua Achebe	Novel, Nigeria	—	Most read African novel; answered colonial stereotypes
1964	Weep Not, Child	Ngũgĩ wa Thiong'o	Novel, Kenya	—	First East African novel in English
1979	So Long a Letter	Mariama Bâ	Novel, Senegal	Noma Award 1980	Classic of African women's writing
1984	The Bone People	Keri Hulme	Novel, New Zealand	Booker 1985	Māori and Pākehā worlds
1999	Disgrace	J. M. Coetzee	Novel, South Africa	Booker 1999	Post-apartheid moral crisis
2006	Half of a Yellow Sun	Chimamanda Ngozi Adichie	Novel, Nigeria	Women's Prize 2007; film (2013)	The Biafran war
2006	Carpentaria	Alexis Wright	Novel, Australia	Miles Franklin 2007	Aboriginal epic of land and law
2020	Afterlives	Abdulrazak Gurnah	Novel, Tanzania/UK	Author's Nobel 2021	Colonial East Africa remembered

☐ BOK-05.6 How the registers grow

The landmark registers above are the trunk. On the website each literature gets year-wise lists, built in this order:

1. **Award lists first** (Sahitya Akademi, Jnanpith, Nobel, Booker and the national awards in Part 5), because they are official and dated.
2. **National bibliographies and library catalogues** (National Library of India, Library of Congress, British Library, WorldCat) for complete publication data.
3. **Canon lists with stated sources** (school and university syllabi, Sahitya Akademi's *Encyclopaedia of Indian Literature*, Norton and Penguin anthologies), always named.
4. **Readers' suggestions**, checked against a source before they are added.

Each entry keeps the same fields as the registers, so lists can later move into a Google Sheet, like the Curriculum Index.

PART 2 — KINDS OF LITERATURE: FORMS AND GENRES

About this Part. The second great classification is what kind of writing a book is. Literature has two great trunks, **poetry** and **prose**, plus **drama** and the **oral tradition**, which mix both. Prose divides into **fiction** and **non-fiction**, and fiction into many **genres**. Sacred texts are a category of their own. Each entry gives a one- or two-line definition and examples from India and the world. Indian poetics (kavya, rasa, dhvani) is covered in Part 6 (BOK-20).

BOK-06 Poetry: the first trunk

Before you start — BOK-06. Poetry is language shaped by rhythm, sound and image, usually in lines. Forms are like containers: a sonnet has fourteen lines, a haiku three, a doha two. Learning a few forms helps you hear poems better. **See also:** MUS (songs and lyrics), BOK-20 Literary theory.

☐ BOK-06.1 Long and narrative poetry

- ☐ **Epic (mahakavya)**: a long story of heroes, gods and nations in elevated verse; *Mahabharata*, *Ramayana*, *Iliad*, *Shahnameh*, *Silappatikaram*, *Paradise Lost*.
- ☐ **Mock epic**: epic style for trivial things; Pope's *The Rape of the Lock*.
- ☐ **Ballad**: a short sung story in simple stanzas; English and Scottish ballads, Rajasthani and Punjabi folk ballads (Heer Ranjha).
- ☐ **Verse novel**: a novel in verse; Pushkin's *Eugene Onegin*, Vikram Seth's *The Golden Gate* (1986).
- ☐ **Akhyana and kathakavya**: Indian narrative poems sung by storytellers; Premanand's Gujarati akhyanas.

☐ BOK-06.2 Lyric poetry

- ☐ **Lyric**: a short poem of personal feeling, originally sung to the lyre; Sappho, Mirabai, Keats.
- ☐ **Ode**: a formal poem of praise or reflection; Pindar, Keats's "Ode to a Nightingale".
- ☐ **Elegy and marsiya**: poems of mourning; Gray's "Elegy", Urdu marsiya on Karbala (Mir Anis, Mirza Dabeer).
- ☐ **Pastoral**: idealised country life; Theocritus, Virgil's *Eclogues*.
- ☐ **Pada and bhajan**: devotional songs of the bhakti saints (Surdas, Meera, Tukaram's abhangas).

☐ BOK-06.3 Fixed forms of Europe

- ☐ **Sonnet**: fourteen lines; Petrarchan (8 + 6) and Shakespearean (4 + 4 + 4 + 2).
- ☐ **Villanelle**: nineteen lines with two repeating refrains; Dylan Thomas's "Do not go gentle".
- ☐ **Terza rima**: interlocking three-line stanzas; Dante.
- ☐ **Blank verse**: unrhymed iambic pentameter; Shakespeare, Milton; brought into Bengali by Michael Madhusudan Dutt (amitrakshar chhanda).
- ☐ **Limerick**: five comic lines; Edward Lear.

☐ BOK-06.4 Forms of the Persian and Urdu world

- ☐ **Ghazal**: rhyming couplets (sher), each complete in itself, with a repeated refrain (radif) and rhyme (qafiya), the poet's pen name (takhallus) in the last couplet (maqta); Hafez, Mir, Ghalib, Faiz; now written in Hindi, English and other languages.
- ☐ **Qasida**: a long ode of praise.
- ☐ **Masnavi**: rhyming couplets for long narratives; Rumi.
- ☐ **Rubai**: a four-line quatrain (AABA); Omar Khayyam.
- ☐ **Nazm**: Urdu poem on a single theme, freer than the ghazal; Iqbal, Faiz.
- ☐ **Qawwali and kafi**: Sufi poems for singing; Amir Khusrau, Bulleh Shah.

☐ BOK-06.5 Forms of India

☐ **Shloka (anushtubh)**: Sanskrit couplet of 32 syllables, the metre of the epics.
☐ **Doha**: two-line Hindi couplet (13 + 11 matras per half); Kabir, Rahim, Bihari.
☐ **Chaupai**: four-part metre used with dohas in the *Ramcharitmanas* and the Hanuman Chalisa.
☐ **Soratha, kavitt, savaiya, chhappay**: other Hindi metres of the riti and bhakti poets.
☐ **Venba and kural**: Tamil metres; the *Thirukkural* couplet.
☐ **Vachana**: Kannada free prose-poem of the 12th century.
☐ **Abhanga and ovi**: Marathi devotional metres.
☐ **Vakh and shruk**: Kashmiri mystic verses of Lal Ded and Nund Rishi.
☐ **Shayari and mushaira**: the culture of reciting couplets at public poetry gatherings; kavi sammelan in Hindi.

☐ BOK-06.6 Forms of East Asia

☐ **Haiku**: Japanese three-phrase poem (5–7–5 sounds) with a season word (kigo); Bashō.
☐ **Tanka and waka**: five-line Japanese poem (5–7–5–7–7).
☐ **Renga**: linked verse written by several poets in turn.
☐ **Sijo**: Korean three-line poem.
☐ **Shi and ci**: Chinese regulated verse and song lyrics.

☐ BOK-06.7 Modern and new poetry

☐ **Free verse**: no fixed metre or rhyme; Whitman, Nirala's mukt chhand, Nayi Kavita.
☐ **Prose poem**: poetry in paragraphs; Baudelaire, Tagore's later work.
☐ **Concrete and visual poetry**: shape on the page as meaning.
☐ **Spoken word and slam**: poetry for performance; India's open-mic scene.
☐ **Song lyrics and rap**: Bob Dylan's Nobel (2016); Gulzar, Javed Akhtar and Sahir in film (MUS).
☐ **Instapoetry**: short poems shared on social media; Rupi Kaur.

BOK-07 Prose fiction: the forms of storytelling

Before you start — BOK-07. Fiction is invented narrative in prose. Its forms are mainly sorted by length. Word counts are common publishing guides (for example, those used by the Hugo and Nebula awards), not strict laws. **See also:** BOK-10 Genre fiction, BOK-18 The craft of writing.

☐ BOK-07.1 Forms by length

☐ **Novel**: a long prose fiction, usually over 40,000 words; room for many characters and years.
☐ **Novella**: 17,500 to 40,000 words (Hugo/Nebula guide); Kafka's *The Metamorphosis*, Hemingway's *The Old Man and the Sea*.
☐ **Novelette**: 7,500 to 17,500 words.
☐ **Short story**: readable in one sitting; Chekhov, Premchand, Manto, Munro, O. Henry, Maupassant.
☐ **Flash fiction and micro-fiction**: under about 1,000 words; the six-word story.
☐ **Fable, parable and fairy tale**: short moral or magical tales; Aesop, Panchatantra, Jataka, Grimm, Andersen.
☐ **Frame story**: stories inside a story; *Arabian Nights*, *Panchatantra*, *Decameron*, *Kathasaritsagara*.

☐ BOK-07.2 Kinds of novel by form

☐ **Epistolary**: told in letters; *Dracula*, *Frankenstein* in part.
☐ **Bildungsroman**: the growing-up novel; *Great Expectations*, *Pather Panchali*.
☐ **Picaresque**: adventures of a rogue on the road; *Lazarillo de Tormes*.
☐ **Historical novel**: fiction set in a real past; Walter Scott, *Ponniyin Selvan*, Mantel's *Wolf Hall*.
☐ **Saga and roman-fleuve**: a long family or multi-volume story; *Buddenbrooks*, *The Forsyte Saga*.

☐ **Stream of consciousness**: following thoughts as they flow; Woolf, Joyce.

☐ **Metafiction**: fiction aware of being fiction; Calvino's *If on a winter's night a traveler*.

☐ **Anchalik (regional) novel**: Hindi novels rooted in one region's dialect and life; Renu's *Maila Anchal*.

☐ **Partition literature**: stories of 1947; Manto, Bhisham Sahni, Amrita Pritam, Khushwant Singh's *Train to Pakistan*.

☐ BOK-07.3 Modes of fiction

☐ **Realism**: life as it is; Premchand, Tolstoy, George Eliot.

☐ **Naturalism**: people shaped by heredity and environment; Zola.

☐ **Magical realism**: magic told as normal; García Márquez, Rushdie.

☐ **Satire**: ridicule to expose folly; Swift, Shrilal Shukla, Harishankar Parsai (vyangya).

☐ **Allegory**: story with a second, symbolic meaning; Bunyan, Orwell's *Animal Farm*.

☐ **Absurdism**: life without meaning shown through strangeness; Kafka, Camus, Beckett.

BOK-08 Non-fiction: true stories and ideas

Before you start — BOK-08. Non-fiction claims to be true. Its value depends on evidence, honesty and clear writing. Many of the best-selling books in India are non-fiction: exam guides, biographies and self-help. **See also:** Curriculum Index (subject books), BOK-17 Best-sellers.

☐ BOK-08.1 Life writing

☐ **Biography**: a life written by someone else; Boswell's *Life of Johnson*, Rajmohan Gandhi's lives of Gandhi and Patel.

☐ **Autobiography**: one's own life; Gandhi's *The Story of My Experiments with Truth*, Nehru's *An Autobiography*, Ambedkar's *Waiting for a Visa*, A. P. J. Abdul Kalam's *Wings of Fire*.

☐ **Memoir**: a part of one's life or one theme; Maya Angelou, Michelle Obama's *Becoming*, Mamta Kalia's *Jeete Jee Allahabad* (Sahitya Akademi 2025).

☐ **Diary and letters**: Anne Frank's diary; Nehru's *Letters from a Father to His Daughter*; Ghalib's letters.

☐ **Charita and tazkira**: Indian royal biographies (*Harshacharita*) and Persian biographical dictionaries of poets; the Mughal memoirs *Baburnama* and Jahangir's *Tuzuk*.

☐ BOK-08.2 Knowledge and argument

☐ **Essay**: a short exploration of one idea; Montaigne invented the word ("attempt"); Bacon, Orwell, Hazari Prasad Dwivedi, Ramachandra Shukla (Hindi nibandh).

☐ **Philosophy**: Plato's dialogues, the Upanishads, Confucius, Kant, Simone de Beauvoir, Ambedkar's *Annihilation of Caste* (1936).

☐ **History**: Herodotus, Sima Qian, Kalhana, Ibn Khaldun, Abul Fazl's *Akbarnama*, Romila Thapar, Ramachandra Guha (*India after Gandhi*), William Dalrymple.

☐ **Popular science**: Darwin's *On the Origin of Species* (1859), Carl Sagan's *Cosmos*, Stephen Hawking's *A Brief History of Time*, Richard Dawkins, Siddhartha Mukherjee (*The Emperor of All Maladies*, Pulitzer 2011), Jayant Narlikar.

☐ **Politics and economics**: Kautilya's *Arthashastra*, Machiavelli's *The Prince*, Adam Smith, Marx and Engels, Amartya Sen (*The Argumentative Indian*), Thomas Piketty.

☐ **Self-help and personal development**: Dale Carnegie, Stephen Covey, James Clear's *Atomic Habits*; read with a critical eye.

☐ BOK-08.3 Narrative and practical non-fiction

☐ **Travel writing**: Xuanzang, Ibn Battuta, Marco Polo, Al-Biruni's *Kitab al-Hind* (about 1030), Rahul Sankrityayan ("father of Hindi travel writing"), Pico Iyer.

☐ **Journalism and reportage**: P. Sainath's *Everybody Loves a Good Drought*, Katherine Boo's *Behind the Beautiful Forevers*, Svetlana Alexievich (Nobel 2015, oral history).

☐ **True crime**: Truman Capote's *In Cold Blood*.

☐ **Nature writing**: Gilbert White, Rachel Carson's *Silent Spring* (1962, launched modern environmentalism), Salim Ali's *The Book of Indian Birds*, Jim Corbett.

☐ **Reference books**: dictionaries, encyclopedias (Diderot's *Encyclopédie*, Britannica since 1768, Wikipedia since 2001), atlases, almanacs, panchangs.

☐ **How-to, cookbooks and craft books**: links to COK, GRD, CRO, KNT, EMB and SEW indexes.

☐ **Textbooks and exam guides**: NCERT books, competitive-exam guides (links to the Curriculum Index and Exam Guide).

BOK-09 Drama and the oral tradition

Before you start — BOK-09. Drama is literature written to be performed, and oral literature is literature that lives in performance. Both are often missed when people think "books". **See also:** MOV-18 (rasa in cinema), MUS.

☐ BOK-09.1 Drama on the page and stage

☐ **Sanskrit nataka and prakarana**: heroic and social plays; Kalidasa, Shudraka; rules in the *Natyashastra*.

☐ **Greek tragedy and comedy**: the origin of Western drama.

☐ **Noh, kabuki and Chinese opera**: East Asian theatre forms.

☐ **Shakespearean and Elizabethan drama**.

☐ **Modern realist drama**: Ibsen, Chekhov, Arthur Miller, Tennessee Williams.

☐ **Theatre of the Absurd**: Beckett (*Waiting for Godot*), Ionesco.

☐ **Modern Indian theatre**: Tagore, Mohan Rakesh (*Ashadh Ka Ek Din*), Vijay Tendulkar, Badal Sircar (Third Theatre), Girish Karnad (*Tughlaq*, *Hayavadana*), Habib Tanvir (*Charandas Chor*), Safdar Hashmi (street theatre).

☐ **Folk drama**: Yakshagana, Jatra, Tamasha, Nautanki, Khyal (Rajasthan), Bhavai, Terukkuttu, Ramlila.

☐ BOK-09.2 Oral literature

☐ **Oral epics**: Pabuji, Devnarayan, Alha-Udal, the *Manas*, *Sundiata*.

☐ **Folk tales**: collected by the Grimms, Verrier Elwin, A. K. Ramanujan (*Folktales from India*, 1991), Vijaydan Detha.

☐ **Proverbs, riddles and lullabies**: the smallest literature, and among the oldest.

☐ **Myth**: sacred stories of origins (see BOK-11 and BOK-20.4).

☐ **Urban legends and internet folklore**: new oral literature online.

BOK-10 Genre fiction: the shelves of the bookshop

Before you start — BOK-10. Genres are families of stories with shared expectations: a mystery promises a solution, a romance promises love at the centre. "Literary fiction" is itself sometimes treated as a genre. Genres mix freely. **See also:** MOV-06 Film genres (many films adapt genre books).

☐ BOK-10.1 Mystery, crime and detective fiction

A crime, an investigation and a solution. Poe's Dupin (1841), Wilkie Collins's *The Moonstone* (1868), Arthur Conan Doyle's Sherlock Holmes (1887), Agatha Christie, Georges Simenon; India's Byomkesh Bakshi (Sharadindu Bandyopadhyay), Feluda (Satyajit Ray), Ibn-e-Safi's Urdu spy novels, Surender Mohan Pathak, Hindi "pulp" (lugdi) novels.

☐ **Sub-genres**: cozy, hard-boiled (Chandler, Hammett), police procedural, Nordic noir, legal thriller, locked-room mystery, historical mystery.

☐ BOK-10.2 Thriller and suspense

Danger and a race against time. John Buchan, Ian Fleming (James Bond), John le Carré (espionage), Frederick Forsyth, Dan Brown, Lee Child; India's Ashwin Sanghi, Mukul Deva. Sub-genres: spy, techno-thriller, psychological thriller, political thriller.

☐ BOK-10.3 Romance

A central love story with an emotionally satisfying ending. Jane Austen as ancestor; Mills & Boon (1908) and Harlequin; Nora Roberts, Colleen Hoover; India's Anuja Chauhan, Durjoy Datta and Hindi and Urdu romances. Sub-genres: historical, contemporary, romantic comedy, paranormal, "romantasy".

☐ BOK-10.4 Fantasy

Magic and invented worlds. Roots in myth and epic; George MacDonald, Tolkien (*The Lord of the Rings*), C. S. Lewis, Ursula K. Le Guin, Terry Pratchett, J. K. Rowling, George R. R. Martin, N. K. Jemisin (three Hugos in a row, 2016–2018); Indian mythological fantasy: Amish's Shiva Trilogy, Samit Basu, Anand Neelakantan. Sub-genres: high/epic, urban, sword and sorcery, mythic, grimdark, portal fantasy.

☐ BOK-10.5 Science fiction

Stories driven by science, technology and "what if". Mary Shelley, Jules Verne, H. G. Wells, Asimov, Arthur C. Clarke, Philip K. Dick, Octavia Butler, Liu Cixin; India's Jagadish Chandra Bose (*Niruddesher Kahini*, 1896), Begum Rokeya Sakhawat Hossain (*Sultana's Dream*, 1905, feminist utopia), Satyajit Ray's Professor Shonku, Jayant Narlikar, Vandana Singh. Sub-genres: hard SF, space opera, cyberpunk, dystopia, climate fiction (cli-fi), solarpunk, afrofuturism.

☐ BOK-10.6 Horror and the gothic

Fear, the uncanny and the supernatural. Horace Walpole (*The Castle of Otranto*, 1764), Bram Stoker (*Dracula*, 1897), H. P. Lovecraft, Stephen King, Shirley Jackson; Indian ghost stories (bhoot katha), Ruskin Bond's ghost tales, Rabindranath's "Kshudhita Pashan" (The Hungry Stones).

☐ BOK-10.7 Historical and adventure fiction

Swashbucklers, quests and the past re-imagined. Dumas (*The Three Musketeers*), Stevenson (*Treasure Island*), Kalki's *Ponniyin Selvan*, Devaki Nandan Khatri's *Chandrakanta* (1888, a Hindi bestseller that made people learn Hindi to read it).

☐ BOK-10.8 Children's and young adult (YA) books

- ☐ **Picture books**: Eric Carle, Maurice Sendak; Tulika and Pratham Books in India.
- ☐ **Children's classics**: *Alice's Adventures in Wonderland*, *The Jungle Book* (Kipling, set in India), *Pinocchio*, Enid Blyton, Roald Dahl, *Panchatantra* retold, *Amar Chitra Katha* (1967, Anant Pai), *Chandamama* (1947), *Champak*, *Tinkle*.
- ☐ **Young adult**: S. E. Hinton's *The Outsiders* (1967) as an early landmark; *Harry Potter*, *The Hunger Games*; Paro Anand.
- ☐ **Award**: Hans Christian Andersen Award, Newbery and Carnegie medals, Sahitya Akademi Bal Sahitya Puraskar.

☐ BOK-10.9 Comics, graphic novels and manga

- ☐ **Comics**: comic strips and books; *Tintin* (Hergé), *Asterix*, Marvel and DC superheroes; India's *Amar Chitra Katha*, *Chacha Chaudhary* (Pran, 1971), Raj Comics, Diamond Comics.
- ☐ **Graphic novel**: long-form comics; Art Spiegelman's *Maus* (Pulitzer special citation 1992), Marjane Satrapi's *Persepolis*; Sarnath Banerjee's *Corridor* (2004, often called India's first graphic novel), Orijit Sen's *River of Stories* (1994).
- ☐ **Manga and manhwa**: Japanese and Korean comics; Osamu Tezuka ("god of manga"), *One Piece*, webtoons.

☐ BOK-10.10 Literary fiction and other shelves

- ☐ **Literary fiction**: focused on style, character and ideas more than plot; most Booker winners.
- ☐ **Speculative fiction**: umbrella term for SF, fantasy and horror.
- ☐ **Western, sea story, war novel, campus novel, sports fiction (SPT), food fiction (COK)**.
- ☐ **Fan fiction and web novels**: readers writing in others' worlds; Wattpad, Archive of Our Own (Hugo Award 2019 for Best Related Work), Pratilipi in Indian languages.

BOK-11 Sacred and scriptural texts

Before you start — BOK-11. Sacred texts are some of the oldest, most read and most translated books in the world. This index lists them as literature and as cultural heritage, respectfully and without ranking faiths. Each tradition's own understanding of its texts comes first. **See also:** BOK-21 Literature and society.

☐ BOK-11.1 Texts of Indian traditions

☐ **Hindu**: shruti (the Vedas and Upanishads) and smriti (epics, Puranas, Dharmashastras, Agamas); the *Bhagavad Gita*.

☐ **Buddhist**: the Pali Tipitaka, Mahayana sutras (such as the *Lotus Sutra*, *Heart Sutra*), the Tibetan Kangyur and Tengyur.

☐ **Jain**: Agamas; Umaswati's *Tattvartha Sutra*; the *Kalpa Sutra*.

☐ **Sikh**: Sri Guru Granth Sahib (compiled 1604, installed as eternal Guru in 1708), with verses of six Gurus and fifteen bhagats including Kabir, Namdev, Ravidas and Farid.

☐ BOK-11.2 Texts of West Asian traditions

☐ **Jewish**: the Tanakh (Torah, Prophets, Writings) and Talmud.

☐ **Christian**: the Bible (Old and New Testaments); the most printed and translated book in history (full Bible in over 700 languages, according to Wycliffe Global Alliance).

☐ **Islamic**: the Qur'an (revealed in Arabic in the 7th century) and the Hadith collections.

☐ **Zoroastrian / Parsi**: the Avesta, including the Gathas of Zarathustra.

☐ **Bahá'í**: the Kitáb-i-Aqdas.

☐ BOK-11.3 Texts of East Asian and other traditions

☐ **Chinese**: the Confucian classics and the *Daodejing*; the *I Ching*.

☐ **Japanese Shinto**: *Kojiki* and *Nihon Shoki*.

☐ **Indigenous sacred narratives**: the *Popol Vuh*, Aboriginal Dreaming stories, African creation myths.

PART 3 — HISTORY: THE STORY OF THE BOOK AND OF LITERATURE

About this Part. The book's history is told twice. First as **material history** (what people wrote on and how copies were made), then as **literary history** (the movements and ages of writing). The intro twig in Part 0 is the two-minute version; this is the full map. Dates for ancient events are scholarly estimates.

BOK-12 Timeline of the book: from memory to machine

Before you start — BOK-12. Every age changed the body of the book: what it was made of, who could copy it and who could read it. Follow India and the world side by side. **See also:** TEC (printing, paper and digital technology), BOK-19 Publishing.

☐ BOK-12.1 Before writing (to about 3300 BCE)

- ☐ **Oral literature** everywhere: myths, songs and law kept in memory; cave art and symbols as early storytelling.
- ☐ **Vedic oral transmission** in India from about 1500 BCE, still alive today.

☐ BOK-12.2 Early writing systems (about 3300 BCE to 500 BCE)

- ☐ **Cuneiform** on clay (Sumer, about 3300–3100 BCE); the library of Ashurbanipal (7th century BCE).
- ☐ **Hieroglyphs and papyrus** (Egypt, from about 3200 BCE).
- ☐ **Indus script** (about 2600–1900 BCE): undeciphered seals.
- ☐ **Chinese oracle-bone script** (about 1200 BCE), ancestor of today's characters.
- ☐ **The alphabet**: Proto-Sinaitic and Phoenician scripts (about 1900–1050 BCE), parent of Greek, Latin, Arabic and Hebrew; Aramaic influenced Kharosthi.

☐ BOK-12.3 Scripts and manuscripts of India (about 300 BCE to 1800 CE)

- ☐ **Brahmi** in the edicts of Ashoka (3rd century BCE), parent of almost all Indian and South-East Asian scripts; **Kharosthi** in the north-west.
- ☐ **Tamil-Brahmi** cave inscriptions (from about the 3rd–2nd century BCE).
- ☐ **Palm leaf and birch bark** manuscripts; copper-plate grants; Jain bhandars; the **Gilgit** and **Bakhshali** manuscripts.
- ☐ **Great libraries**: Nalanda (5th–12th century) with its library called Dharmaganja; Vikramashila; Mughal imperial library; Saraswati Mahal Library, Thanjavur (one of Asia's oldest surviving libraries); Khuda Bakhsh Library, Patna (1891); Raza Library, Rampur.
- ☐ **Illustrated manuscripts**: Jain *Kalpa Sutra* paintings, Mughal *Hamzanama* and *Razmnama* (Persian Mahabharata), Rajput and Pahari painted Gita Govindas.

☐ BOK-12.4 Scroll to codex and the medieval book (about 1st to 14th century)

- ☐ **Codex**: bound pages, spreading in the Roman world from the 1st century CE and favoured by early Christians.
- ☐ **Paper** invented in China (traditionally Cai Lun, 105 CE); spread to Samarkand (751), Baghdad (about 794), Spain and later Europe.
- ☐ **Monastic scriptoria** and illuminated manuscripts (the *Book of Kells*, about 800).
- ☐ **The Islamic book**: Baghdad's House of Wisdom, calligraphy, bookbinding, paper mills; Timbuktu manuscripts.

☐ BOK-12.5 Printing (868 to 1800)

- ☐ **Woodblock printing** in China; the *Diamond Sutra* (868, oldest dated printed book).
- ☐ **Movable type**: Bi Sheng (clay, about 1040); Korea's *Jikji* (metal, 1377).
- ☐ **Gutenberg** (Mainz, about 1450; 42-line Bible about 1455); the "incunabula" (books printed before 1501).

☐ **Printing in India**: Goa (1556), the Tamil *Thambiran Vanakkam* (1578), Danish missionaries at Tranquebar (1712; Ziegenbalg's Tamil Bible), Calcutta presses (1777 onward), Serampore Mission Press (1800), Fort William College (1800) and its Hindi and Urdu prose books.

☐ **Newspapers**: *Hicky's Bengal Gazette* (1780), *Samachar Darpan* (Bengali, 1818), *Udant Martand* (first Hindi newspaper, 30 May 1826, now Hindi Journalism Day), *Jam-e-Jahan-Numa* (Urdu/Persian, 1822).

☐ BOK-12.6 The age of mass print (1800 to 1990)

☐ **Steam presses and cheap paper**: books and magazines for everyone; serialised novels (Dickens).

☐ **Lithography** made printing Urdu nastaliq and Indian scripts easy; Nawal Kishore Press, Lucknow (1858), printed thousands of titles in Urdu, Hindi, Persian, Sanskrit and Arabic.

☐ **Copyright laws**: Statute of Anne (Britain, 1710); Berne Convention (1886); India's Copyright Act (1957).

☐ **Public libraries**: Andrew Carnegie's libraries; India's library movement led by S. R. Ranganathan ("father of library science", Colon Classification, *Five Laws of Library Science*, 1931); the Madras Public Libraries Act (1948).

☐ **Paperback revolution**: Penguin Books (1935, Allen Lane); Indian publishers such as Rajkamal Prakashan (1947), Hind Pocket Books (1958, pioneered Hindi paperbacks), National Book Trust (1957).

☐ **Literacy**: India's literacy rose from about 18% (1951 census) to 74% (2011 census).

☐ BOK-12.7 The digital book (1971 to today)

☐ **Project Gutenberg** (1971), the first e-library; the **ISBN** (international from 1970).

☐ **Online bookselling**: Amazon (1995); Flipkart started as an online bookshop (2007).

☐ **E-readers**: Sony Reader (2006), Amazon Kindle (2007); Google Books scanning (2004).

☐ **Audiobooks and podcasts**: Audible (1995), Storytel; Indian-language audio platforms.

☐ **Web fiction and self-publishing**: Kindle Direct Publishing (2007), Wattpad (2006), Pratilipi (2014), Chinese web literature.

☐ **Digital libraries**: National Digital Library of India (IIT Kharagpur), Internet Archive, HathiTrust, Europeana, the Digital Library of India.

☐ **AI era (2020s)**: AI writing, translation and narration tools; lawsuits and debates on training data and authorship (BOK-19.5).

BOK-13 Literary ages and movements

Before you start — BOK-13. Movements are groups of writers who share a style, a purpose or a rebellion. Indian literature has its own movements, which often ran in parallel with or answered European ones. **See also:** MOV-08 Film movements, MUS (song movements).

☐ BOK-13.1 Indian movements and ages

☐ **Sangam age** (Tamil, about 300 BCE to 300 CE).

☐ **Classical Sanskrit kavya** (about 1st to 12th century).

☐ **Bhakti movement** (Tamil Nadu from the 6th century, then across India to the 17th): devotion in the people's languages; Alvars, Nayanars, Basavanna, Dnyaneshwar, Kabir, Ravidas, Surdas, Tulsidas, Meera, Chaitanya, Sankardev, Guru Nanak.

☐ **Sufi poetry**: Amir Khusrau, Bulleh Shah, Shah Latif, Lal Ded's mystic kin.

☐ **Riti kal** (Hindi court poetry, about 1650–1850).

☐ **Bengal Renaissance** (19th century): Rammohun Roy, Vidyasagar, Bankim, Tagore.

☐ **Nationalist literature**: "Vande Mataram", Bharati, Maithili Sharan Gupt (*Bharat-Bharati*), Makhanlal Chaturvedi, Subhadra Kumari Chauhan ("Jhansi ki Rani").

☐ **Chhayavad** (Hindi romanticism, 1918–1936): Prasad, Nirala, Pant, Mahadevi Verma.

☐ **Progressive Writers' Movement** (1936): literature for social change; Premchand, Faiz, Mulk Raj Anand, Sajjad Zaheer.

☐ **Prayogvad and Nayi Kavita** (from 1943): Agyeya's *Tar Saptak*, experimental Hindi poetry.

☐ **Nayi Kahani** (1950s): Mohan Rakesh, Kamleshwar, Rajendra Yadav.

☐ **Hungry Generation** (Bengali, 1961) and **Digambara poets** (Telugu, 1965): angry avant-garde poetry.

☐ **Navya** (Kannada modernism): Gopalakrishna Adiga, U. R. Ananthamurthy.

☐ **Dalit literature** (Marathi from the 1960s, then all languages): Ambedkarite writing of dignity and protest.

☐ **Feminist and women's writing**: Ismat Chughtai, Kamala Das, Mahasweta Devi, Ambai, Mridula Garg; Kali for Women (1984), India's first feminist press.

☐ **Indian English "Midnight's children" generation** (from 1981).

☐ **Adivasi and North-east literatures** (21st century).

☐ BOK-13.2 World movements, in order

☐ **Classical** (Greece and Rome): order, balance, imitation of nature.

☐ **Medieval** (about 500–1400): romance, allegory, courtly love, the troubadours.

☐ **Renaissance** (about 1300–1650): humanism; Petrarch, Shakespeare, Cervantes.

☐ **Baroque and Neoclassicism** (17th–18th century): Molière, Pope, Racine.

☐ **Enlightenment** (18th century): reason and satire; Voltaire, Swift.

☐ **Romanticism** (about 1790–1850): feeling, nature, the individual; Wordsworth, Goethe, Pushkin. Inspired by translated Sanskrit literature (Shakuntala and the Gita).

☐ **Realism and Naturalism** (about 1830–1900): Balzac, Flaubert, Tolstoy, Zola.

☐ **Symbolism and Aestheticism** (late 19th century): Baudelaire, Mallarmé, Oscar Wilde.

☐ **Modernism** (about 1900–1945): breaking forms; Joyce, Woolf, Eliot, Kafka, Proust.

☐ **Harlem Renaissance** (1920s): Black American voices.

☐ **Négritude** (1930s): Césaire, Senghor.

☐ **Existentialism and the Absurd** (1940s–50s): Sartre, Camus, Beckett.

☐ **The Beat Generation** (1950s): Ginsberg, Kerouac; some travelled in India.

☐ **Latin American Boom and magical realism** (1960s–70s).

☐ **Postmodernism** (from the 1960s): irony, play, metafiction; Pynchon, Calvino, Rushdie.

☐ **Postcolonial literature** (from the 1950s): Achebe, Ngũgĩ, Walcott, Rushdie, Roy.

☐ **Contemporary trends** (21st century): autofiction (Knausgård, Annie Ernaux), climate fiction, translated fiction boom, BookTok-driven bestsellers.

BOK-14 Authors: the people of literature

Before you start — BOK-14. A selection of writers whose work shaped literature, sorted by role. Each name gets a profile page on the website with life, major works, a short reading path and sources. Many more appear in the language sections of Part 1. **See also:** BOK-15 Nobel laureates, BOK-16.1 Jnanpith winners.

☐ BOK-14.1 Founders and ancient masters

☐ **Enheduanna** (Sumer): first named author. **Homer** (Greece): the epics. **Valmiki** and **Vyasa** (India, by tradition): the epics. **Confucius** and **Laozi** (China). **Sappho** (Greece): lyric. **Kalidasa** (India): poet-dramatist. **Thiruvalluvar** (Tamil): the *Kural*.

☐ BOK-14.2 Poets of the bhakti and Sufi worlds

☐ Andal, Basavanna, Akka Mahadevi, Lal Ded, Kabir, Ravidas, Meera, Surdas, Tulsidas, Tukaram, Guru Nanak, Rumi, Hafez, Amir Khusrau, Bulleh Shah: poets who spoke directly to God in the people's language.

☐ BOK-14.3 Great novelists of the world

☐ Murasaki Shikibu, Cervantes, Cao Xueqin, Austen, Dickens, Tolstoy, Dostoevsky, George Eliot, Flaubert, Hugo, Twain, Proust, Joyce, Woolf, Kafka, Thomas Mann, Faulkner, García Márquez, Achebe, Mahfouz, Morrison, Kawabata, Murakami.

☐ BOK-14.4 Great Indian novelists and storytellers

☐ Bankim Chandra, Tagore, Sarat Chandra, Premchand, Fakir Mohan Senapati, Bibhutibhushan, R. K. Narayan, Manto, Ismat Chughtai, Qurratulain Hyder, Thakazhi, Basheer, Shivaram Karanth, U. R. Ananthamurthy, Mahasweta Devi, Krishna Sobti, Nirmal Verma, Vijaydan Detha, O. V. Vijayan, Salman Rushdie, Amitav Ghosh, Arundhati Roy, Perumal Murugan, Geetanjali Shree, Banu Mushtaq.

☐ BOK-14.5 Women writers who changed literature

☐ Enheduanna, Sappho, Murasaki Shikibu, Akka Mahadevi, Meera, Mary Wollstonecraft, Jane Austen, Mary Shelley, the Brontës, George Eliot, Emily Dickinson, Virginia Woolf, Mahadevi Verma, Amrita Pritam, Ismat Chughtai, Toni Morrison, Kamala Das, Mahasweta Devi, Maya Angelou, Margaret Atwood, Wisława Szymborska, Han Kang, Annie Ernaux; and Tarabai Shinde, whose *Stri Purush Tulana* (1882) is an early Indian feminist text.

☐ BOK-14.6 Translators: the invisible authors

☐ Kumarajiva and Xuanzang (Sanskrit to Chinese), Ibn al-Muqaffa (Panchatantra into Arabic), Dara Shikoh (Upanishads into Persian, 1657), William Jones and Charles Wilkins (Sanskrit into English), Edward FitzGerald, Constance Garnett (Russian), A. K. Ramanujan, Gregory Rabassa (García Márquez), Daisy Rockwell, Deepa Bhasthi, Lin King. Since 2016 the International Booker splits its prize equally between author and translator.

☐ BOK-14.7 Best-selling and popular authors

☐ Agatha Christie (often listed by Guinness as the best-selling fiction writer of all time, with an estimated 2 billion copies), Shakespeare, Barbara Cartland, Danielle Steel, J. K. Rowling, Stephen King, Paulo Coelho, Enid Blyton, Dr. Seuss; in India Gulshan Nanda, Ibn-e-Safi, Ved Prakash Sharma (*Vardi Wala Gunda*), Surender Mohan Pathak, Ruskin Bond, Chetan Bhagat, Amish Tripathi, Sudha Murty.

PART 4 — AWARDS, PRIZES AND RECORDS

About this Part. Each award has the same card: **who gives it, since when, for what, the first winner, landmark winners and the latest winner**, with the date it was checked. Prizes are a guide, not a verdict: many great writers (Tolstoy, Joyce, Premchand) never won the big international prizes. Latest winners were checked on the web on **3 November 2026**. Where a result was due after that date, the card says so.

BOK-15 International literary prizes

Before you start — BOK-15. Some prizes honour a writer's whole body of work (the Nobel), others a single book (the Booker). Some are open only to English (the Booker), others to translations (the International Booker). **See also:** MOV-10 Film awards (for the same card format).

☐ BOK-15.1 Nobel Prize in Literature

Given by the **Swedish Academy** since **1901** under Alfred Nobel's will, to an author for the body of work "in an ideal direction". **First winner:** Sully Prudhomme (France, 1901). **Landmarks:** Rabindranath Tagore (1913, first non-European), Selma Lagerlöf (1909, first woman), Wole Soyinka (1986, first African), Toni Morrison (1993), Bob Dylan (2016, songwriter), Han Kang (2024, first Asian woman). **Latest: Anne Carson** (Canada, poet, essayist and classicist), announced 8 October 2026; before her, **László Krasznahorkai** (Hungary, 2025). **Tags:** #nobel #award

☐ **Indian-born or Indian-origin laureates**: Rabindranath Tagore (1913); Rudyard Kipling (1907, born in Bombay); V. S. Naipaul (2001, Indo-Trinidadian).

☐ **Prizes not awarded**: in some war years and in 2018 (a Swedish Academy scandal; two prizes given in 2019).

☐ **Declined**: Boris Pasternak (1958, forced by Soviet authorities) and Jean-Paul Sartre (1964, by choice).

Award Register — Nobel Prize in Literature (selected winners)

Year	Laureate	Country	Language	Known for	Note
1901	Sully Prudhomme	France	French	Poetry	First laureate
1913	Rabindranath Tagore	India	Bengali, English	*Gitanjali*	First Asian and non-European
1929	Thomas Mann	Germany	German	*Buddenbrooks*	—
1945	Gabriela Mistral	Chile	Spanish	Poetry	First Latin American
1954	Ernest Hemingway	USA	English	*The Old Man and the Sea*	—
1968	Yasunari Kawabata	Japan	Japanese	*Snow Country*	First Japanese
1982	Gabriel García Márquez	Colombia	Spanish	*One Hundred Years of Solitude*	—
1986	Wole Soyinka	Nigeria	English	Drama, poetry	First African
1988	Naguib Mahfouz	Egypt	Arabic	Cairo Trilogy	First Arabic-language
1993	Toni Morrison	USA	English	*Beloved*	First Black woman
2012	Mo Yan	China	Chinese	*Red Sorghum*	—
2016	Bob Dylan	USA	English	Songs	First songwriter
2021	Abdulrazak Gurnah	Tanzania/UK	English	*Paradise*, *Afterlives*	—
2022	Annie Ernaux	France	French	*The Years*	Autofiction
2023	Jon Fosse	Norway	Nynorsk	Plays and prose	—
2024	Han Kang	South Korea	Korean	*Human Acts*, *The Vegetarian*	First Korean
2025	László Krasznahorkai	Hungary	Hungarian	*Satantango*	—
2026	Anne Carson	Canada	English	*Autobiography of Red*, *Nox*	Latest (announced 8 Oct 2026)

☐ BOK-15.2 The Booker Prize

For the best novel written in English and published in the UK or Ireland. Founded **1969** (as the Booker Prize; "Man Booker" 2002–2019). Open to writers of any nationality since 2014. **First winner:** P. H. Newby, *Something to Answer For* (1969). **Indian and Indian-origin winners:** V. S. Naipaul (1971, *In a Free State*), Salman Rushdie (1981), Arundhati Roy (1997), Kiran Desai (2006), Aravind Adiga (2008). **Landmarks:** Hilary Mantel (twice, 2009 and 2012), "Booker of Bookers" to *Midnight's Children* (1993 and 2008). **Latest:** **David Szalay*, Flesh* **(2025). The** 2026 winner is due on 9 November 2026**; the shortlist is M. John Harrison (*The End of Everything*), Marlon James (*The Disappearers*), Luke Kennard (*Black Bag*), Rebecca Perry (*May We Feed the King*), Elizabeth Strout (*The Things We Never Say*) and Douglas Stuart (*John of John*). Tags:** #booker

☐ BOK-15.3 The International Booker Prize

For a single book of fiction translated into English, with the £50,000 prize **shared equally by author and translator**. Began **2005** as a biennial award for a body of work (first winner Ismail Kadare, Albania); became an annual prize for one translated book in **2016** (first: Han Kang's *The Vegetarian*, tr. Deborah Smith). **Indian winners:** Geetanjali Shree and Daisy Rockwell (*Tomb of Sand*, Hindi, 2022); Banu Mushtaq and Deepa Bhasthi (*Heart Lamp*, Kannada, 2025). **Latest:** ***Taiwan Travelogue*** by **Yang Shuang-zi**, translated from Mandarin by **Lin King** (announced 19 May 2026; first winners from Taiwan). **Tags:** #internationalbooker #translation

☐ BOK-15.4 Other major international prizes

- ☐ **Neustadt International Prize for Literature** (University of Oklahoma, 1970; first winner Giuseppe Ungaretti): called "the American Nobel"; Raja Rao won in 1988. Latest winner: to be checked.
- ☐ **Hans Christian Andersen Award** (IBBY, 1956; first winner Eleanor Farjeon): the highest international honour for children's writers and illustrators, given every two years. **Latest (2026):** Michael Rosen (UK, writing) and Cai Gao (China, illustration).
- ☐ **Astrid Lindgren Memorial Award** (Sweden, 2003): the world's richest children's literature award.
- ☐ **Hugo Award** (World Science Fiction Society, 1953; first Best Novel: Alfred Bester's *The Demolished Man*): voted by fans. **Latest Best Novel (2026):** Alix E. Harrow, *The Everlasting*.
- ☐ **Nebula Award** (Science Fiction and Fantasy Writers Association, 1966; first Best Novel: Frank Herbert's *Dune*): voted by writers.
- ☐ **Women's Prize for Fiction** (UK, 1996; first winner Helen Dunmore, *A Spell of Winter*): for women writing in English. **Latest (2026):** Virginia Evans, a debut novelist.
- ☐ **Dublin Literary Award** (1996): nominated by libraries worldwide.
- ☐ **Prix Goncourt** (France, 1903): see BOK-16.3.
- ☐ **Cervantes Prize** (Spain, 1976): the highest honour in Spanish-language literature.
- ☐ **Camões Prize** (1989): Portuguese-language literature.
- ☐ **Caine Prize / AKO Caine Prize** (2000): African short story in English.
- ☐ **Commonwealth Short Story Prize** (2012): Commonwealth writers, also in translation.
- ☐ **DSC Prize for South Asian Literature** (first awarded 2011 to H. M. Naqvi, *Home Boy*).

BOK-16 National literary awards, country by country

Before you start — BOK-16. National awards honour a country's own literature. India's are unusual because they cover many languages at once. **See also:** Exam Guide (awards are a favourite topic in competitive exams).

☐ BOK-16.1 India

- ☐ **Jnanpith Award** (Bharatiya Jnanpith, first given **1965**): India's highest literary award, for a writer's outstanding contribution in any Eighth Schedule language or in English. **First winner:** G. Sankara Kurup (Malayalam, *Odakkuzhal*, 1965). **Landmarks:** Ashapurna Devi (1976, first woman), Amitav Ghosh (2018, first English writer), Gulzar (Urdu) and Jagadguru Rambhadracharya (Sanskrit) shared the 58th (2023). **Latest:** 59th (2024) **Vinod Kumar Shukla** (Hindi); 60th (2025) **R. Vairamuthu** (Tamil poet and film lyricist), announced 14 March 2026.

☐ **Sahitya Akademi Award** (National Academy of Letters, established 1954; awards since **1955**): one book a year in each of 24 languages. **First Hindi winner:** Makhanlal Chaturvedi (1955, *Him Taringini*). **Latest (2025 awards, announced 16 March 2026):** English: Navtej Sarna, *Crimson Spring* (novel); Hindi: Mamta Kalia, *Jeete Jee Allahabad* (memoir); Rajasthani: Jitender Kumar Soni, *Bharkham*; Tamil: Sa. Tamilselvan; Bengali: Prasun Bandyopadhyay; Urdu: Pritpal Singh Betab.

☐ **Sahitya Akademi Fellowship**: the Akademi's highest honour, for "immortals of literature"; first fellow S. Radhakrishnan (1968).

☐ **Sahitya Akademi Yuva Puraskar** (2011): writers under 35. **Bal Sahitya Puraskar** (2010): children's literature. **Translation Prize** (1989).

☐ **Saraswati Samman** (K. K. Birla Foundation, 1991): for a work in any Eighth Schedule language. **First winner:** Harivansh Rai Bachchan (Hindi, autobiography). **Latest:** 2025 to **Ramkumar Mukhopadhyay** for the Bengali novel *Hara Parbati Katha* (announced March 2026); 2024 to Mahamahopadhyay Bhadreshdas Swami (Sanskrit), the first saint-scholar to receive it.

☐ **Vyas Samman** (K. K. Birla Foundation, 1991): Hindi literature; first winner Ram Vilas Sharma.

☐ **Bihari Puraskar** (K. K. Birla Foundation, 1991): Hindi and Rajasthani writers of Rajasthan.

☐ **JCB Prize for Literature** (2018–): fiction by an Indian writer, including translations; first winner Benyamin's *Jasmine Days* (tr. Shahnaz Habib). Later winners include Perumal Murugan's *Fire Bird* (2023, tr. Janani Kannan). Latest edition: to be checked.

☐ **Kendriya Hindi Sansthan awards, state academies** (Rajasthan Sahitya Akademi, Kerala Sahitya Akademi, Bangla Academy) and **Ezhuthachan Puraskaram** (Kerala's highest).

☐ **Padma awards** to writers, and the **Kabir Samman**, **Kalidas Samman** and **Tulsi Samman** (Madhya Pradesh government).

Award Register — Jnanpith Award (selected years)

Year	Writer	Language	Notable work	Note	Why it matters
1965	G. Sankara Kurup	Malayalam	*Odakkuzhal*	First award	Founded India's top literary honour
1966	Tarashankar Bandyopadhyay	Bengali	*Ganadevata*	—	Rural Bengal epic
1967	Kuvempu and Umashankar Joshi	Kannada, Gujarati	*Sri Ramayana Darshanam*, *Nishitha*	Shared	—
1968	Sumitranandan Pant	Hindi	*Chidambara*	First Hindi	Chhayavad poet
1976	Ashapurna Devi	Bengali	*Pratham Pratishruti*	First woman	—
1982	Mahadevi Verma	Hindi	*Yama*	—	Chhayavad poet
1989	Qurratulain Hyder	Urdu	*Aag ka Darya* and others	—	—
1999	Nirmal Verma and Gurdial Singh	Hindi, Punjabi	Body of work	Shared	—
2013	Kedarnath Singh	Hindi	Body of work	—	—
2018	Amitav Ghosh	English	Body of work	First English	—
2022	Damodar Mauzo	Konkani	Body of work	—	—
2023	Gulzar and Jagadguru Rambhadracharya	Urdu, Sanskrit	Body of work	Shared (58th)	—
2024	Vinod Kumar Shukla	Hindi	*Naukar ki Kameez*, *Deewar Mein Ek Khidki Rahti Thi*	59th	—
2025	R. Vairamuthu	Tamil	Poetry, novels, film songs	60th; latest	—

☐ BOK-16.2 United Kingdom and Ireland

☐ **Booker Prize** (BOK-15.2), **Women's Prize** (BOK-15.4), **Costa / Whitbread Book Awards** (1971–2021, discontinued), **Carnegie Medal** (1936, children's), **Forward Prizes for Poetry** (1992), **T. S. Eliot Prize** (1993), **James Tait Black Prizes** (1919, the oldest British literary award).

☐ BOK-16.3 Europe

☐ **France**: Prix Goncourt (1903; first winner John-Antoine Nau). **Latest (2025):** Laurent Mauvignier, *La Maison vide*. Also Prix Renaudot, Prix Femina.

☐ **Germany**: Georg Büchner Prize (1923), German Book Prize (2005), Peace Prize of the German Book Trade (1950).

☐ **Spain**: Cervantes Prize; Premio Planeta (1952, among the richest).

☐ **Italy**: Premio Strega (1947).

☐ **Russia**: Russian Booker (1992–2019), Big Book Prize.

☐ **Nordic**: Nordic Council Literature Prize (1962).

☐ BOK-16.4 The Americas

☐ **USA**: Pulitzer Prize for Fiction (1918, first winner Ernest Poole, *His Family*); **latest (2026):** Daniel Kraus, *Angel Down*. National Book Award (1950); National Book Critics Circle Award (1975); Newbery Medal (1922, children's) and Caldecott Medal (1938, picture books).

☐ **Canada**: Giller Prize (1994), Governor General's Literary Awards (1936).

☐ **Latin America**: Rómulo Gallegos Prize (Venezuela, 1967), Casa de las Américas Prize (Cuba, 1960), Jabuti Prize (Brazil, 1959).

☐ BOK-16.5 Asia, Africa and Oceania

☐ **Japan**: Akutagawa Prize (1935, literary fiction by new writers) and Naoki Prize (popular fiction), both twice a year.

☐ **China**: Mao Dun Literature Prize (1982), Lu Xun Literary Prize.

☐ **South Korea**: Yi Sang Literary Award (1977).

☐ **Arab world**: International Prize for Arabic Fiction ("Arabic Booker", 2008), Sheikh Zayed Book Award.

☐ **Pakistan**: Pakistan Academy of Letters awards. **Bangladesh**: Bangla Academy Literary Award (1960). **Sri Lanka**: Gratiaen Prize (1993).

☐ **Africa**: Caine Prize, Nigeria Prize for Literature (2004), Wole Soyinka Prize.

☐ **Australia**: Miles Franklin Award (1957). **New Zealand**: Ockham New Zealand Book Awards.

BOK-17 Best-sellers, records and numbers

Before you start — BOK-17. Sales figures for books are **estimates**, often from publishers' own claims, and are hard to compare across centuries and languages. Treat every number as approximate and check its source. **See also:** MOV-13 Film records.

☐ BOK-17.1 The most printed and translated books

☐ **The Bible**: estimated billions of copies; full translations in more than 700 languages (Wycliffe Global Alliance).

☐ **The Qur'an**, the **Bhagavad Gita**, the *__Ramcharitmanas__, *the Hanuman Chalisa** (Gita Press, Gorakhpur, founded 1923, has printed hundreds of millions of copies of Hindu texts).

☐ **Quotations from Chairman Mao** (the "Little Red Book"): estimates of about a billion copies.

☐ **Most translated single literary work besides scripture**: Antoine de Saint-Exupéry's *The Little Prince* (1943), in over 500 languages and dialects; Carlo Collodi's *Pinocchio* is close behind.

☐ **Most translated author** (UNESCO *Index Translationum*, data up to the 2010s): Agatha Christie, then Jules Verne and Shakespeare.

☐ BOK-17.2 Best-selling single works (estimates)

☐ *Don Quixote* (claimed 500 million), *A Tale of Two Cities* (about 200 million), *The Little Prince* (about 200 million), *Harry Potter and the Philosopher's Stone* (over 120 million), *The Hobbit*, *And Then There Were None* (about 100 million), *The Alchemist* (over 150 million claimed by the author's publishers).

☐ **Best-selling series**: *Harry Potter* (over 600 million copies across seven books, according to its publishers).

☐ **India**: *Chandrakanta*, *Godaan*, the Gita Press editions, Chetan Bhagat's novels, Amish's *Shiva Trilogy*, *Wings of Fire*, NCERT textbooks and exam guides (the true best-sellers by volume).

☐ BOK-17.3 Records and curiosities

☐ **Longest epic**: the Kyrgyz *Manas* and the Tibetan *Epic of King Gesar* are often called longer than the *Mahabharata* (about 100,000 shlokas in the full tradition, or about 1.8 million words), depending on how versions are counted.

☐ **Largest library**: the Library of Congress (more than 170 million items); India's largest is the National Library, Kolkata.

☐ **Largest book fairs**: Frankfurt Book Fair (the biggest trade fair), Kolkata International Book Fair (among the largest by visitors), New Delhi World Book Fair (since 1972, organised by the National Book Trust).

☐ **Oldest continuously operating library**: the al-Qarawiyyin library in Fez, Morocco (founded 859).

☐ **India's publishing size**: India is one of the largest book markets and English-language publishers in the world; figures vary by report (Federation of Indian Publishers, Nielsen), so the website will cite the latest dated report.

PART 5 — THE CRAFT AND THE BUSINESS OF BOOKS

About this Part. How a book comes into being: written, edited, designed, printed, translated, sold, kept in libraries and protected by law. This is the "behind the scenes" of literature.

BOK-18 The craft of writing

Before you start — BOK-18. Every book is built from a few basic tools: story, character, point of view, voice, structure and style. Knowing them makes you a sharper reader and a better writer. **See also:** MOV-15 (screenwriting), BOK-20 Theory.

☐ BOK-18.1 Elements of a story

- ☐ **Plot**: the order of events; Aristotle's beginning, middle and end; Freytag's pyramid (exposition, rising action, climax, falling action, resolution).
- ☐ **Character**: round and flat (E. M. Forster, *Aspects of the Novel*, 1927), protagonist and antagonist, the character arc.
- ☐ **Setting**: time and place; Malgudi, Macondo and Middle-earth as places readers "visit".
- ☐ **Point of view**: first person ("I"), third person limited or omniscient, second person ("you"), unreliable narrator.
- ☐ **Theme**: the big idea underneath; love, power, death, freedom, identity.
- ☐ **Conflict**: person against person, nature, society, self or fate.
- ☐ **Structure patterns**: the hero's journey (Joseph Campbell, *The Hero with a Thousand Faces*, 1949), three-act structure, frame tales, non-linear stories.

☐ BOK-18.2 Language and style

- ☐ **Figures of speech (alankara)**: simile (upama), metaphor (rupaka), personification, hyperbole (atishayokti), alliteration (anuprasa), pun (shlesha), irony.
- ☐ **Imagery and symbol**; **tone and mood**; **diction** (word choice); **rhythm** in prose.
- ☐ **Dialogue**: how people talk on the page; dialect writing (Renu, Twain).
- ☐ **Show, don't tell**: let readers infer feelings from action and detail.

☐ BOK-18.3 The writing life

- ☐ **Drafting and revising**: most books go through many drafts; famous writers' routines (Premchand wrote daily; Hemingway stopped mid-sentence to restart next day).
- ☐ **Writing workshops and programmes**: Iowa Writers' Workshop (1936), creative writing courses in India (Ashoka, Jadavpur), Sahitya Akademi workshops.
- ☐ **Writer's block, reading as training, keeping a notebook**.
- ☐ **Writing in your mother tongue**: why many writers, from Ngũgĩ to Premchand (who moved from Urdu to Hindi), thought deeply about language choice.

BOK-19 Publishing, libraries and the law

Before you start — BOK-19. A manuscript becomes a book through a long chain of people: agents, editors, designers, printers, distributors, booksellers and librarians. **See also:** TEC (printing and e-book technology).

☐ BOK-19.1 How a book is published

- ☐ **Literary agent**: finds a publisher for the author (common in the UK and USA, growing in India).
- ☐ **Acquisition and contract**: advance against royalties; royalty rates; rights (translation, film, audio).
- ☐ **Editing**: structural editing, line editing, copy-editing, proofreading, fact-checking.

☐ **Design and production**: cover design, typesetting, typefaces (Garamond, Devanagari fonts such as Mukta), paper, binding (hardback, paperback, saddle-stitch), the ISBN and barcode.

☐ **Printing**: offset printing, print-on-demand; India's printing hub in Sivakasi and Delhi NCR.

☐ **Marketing and launch**: reviews, festivals, social media, BookTok and Bookstagram.

☐ **Distribution and bookselling**: distributors, bookshops (Higginbothams, Chennai, 1844, among India's oldest; College Street, Kolkata, one of the world's biggest second-hand book markets), online stores.

☐ **Self-publishing**: Kindle Direct Publishing, Notion Press (India), Pothi.

☐ BOK-19.2 Publishers of India and the world

☐ **World**: the "Big Five" (Penguin Random House, HarperCollins, Simon & Schuster, Hachette, Macmillan); university presses (Oxford University Press, oldest roots in 1478; Cambridge University Press, 1534, the oldest publishing house in continuous operation).

☐ **India (English)**: Penguin Random House India, HarperCollins India, Rupa, Westland, Aleph, Juggernaut, Speaking Tiger, Seagull Books (Kolkata, translation), Tulika and Karadi Tales (children's), Zubaan (feminist, from Kali for Women).

☐ **India (Indian languages)**: Gita Press (Gorakhpur), Rajkamal and Vani Prakashan (Hindi), DC Books (Malayalam, 1974), Ananda Publishers (Bengali), Kalachuvadu (Tamil), Mauj Prakashan (Marathi), Navajivan (Gujarati, Gandhi's works), Rajpal & Sons, National Book Trust, Sahitya Akademi, Publications Division.

☐ BOK-19.3 Translation

☐ **Why translation matters**: most people read world literature in translation; India reads itself through translation between its languages.

☐ **Ideas of translation**: word-for-word versus sense-for-sense; "domestication" and "foreignisation" (Lawrence Venuti); anuvad in the Indian tradition (literally "saying after").

☐ **Translation institutions**: Sahitya Akademi translation programme, National Translation Mission (CIIL Mysore), Indian Literature Abroad; UNESCO's *Index Translationum*.

☐ BOK-19.4 Libraries and archives

☐ **Kinds of library**: public, academic, national, school, special, digital, mobile (book vans, camel libraries in Rajasthan and Mongolia).

☐ **India**: National Library (Kolkata, from the Imperial Library, 1903), Delhi Public Library (1951, with UNESCO help), Connemara Public Library (Chennai, 1896), state central libraries, Raja Rammohun Roy Library Foundation (1972).

☐ **World**: Library of Congress, British Library, Bibliothèque nationale de France, New York Public Library, Bibliotheca Alexandrina (2002, built in memory of the ancient library).

☐ **Library science**: S. R. Ranganathan's *Five Laws* (books are for use; every reader his or her book; every book its reader; save the time of the reader; the library is a growing organism); Dewey Decimal Classification (1876); Colon Classification (1933).

☐ BOK-19.5 Copyright, public domain and censorship

☐ **Copyright**: the author's right over copying; in India it lasts for the author's life plus 60 years (Copyright Act, 1957); life plus 70 years in the EU and USA.

☐ **Public domain**: works free for all once copyright ends; that is why Project Gutenberg can share classics. Tagore's works entered the public domain in India in 2002.

☐ **Fair use / fair dealing**: limited quoting for review, study and criticism; the rule this index follows.

☐ **Open licences**: Creative Commons (2001); Wikipedia and open textbooks.

☐ **AI and copyright**: lawsuits over training AI on books without permission (2023 onward); questions of AI authorship; how Curious Sparoows labels AI-assisted work.

☐ **Censorship and banned books**: Ovid's exile, *Ulysses* (banned in the USA until 1933), *Lady Chatterley's Lover* (trial 1960), *The Satanic Verses* (import banned in India, 1988), the American Library Association's Banned Books Week (since 1982).

PART 6 — IDEAS: THEORY, PHILOSOPHY, PSYCHOLOGY AND SOCIETY

About this Part. Why literature matters and how people have thought about it, from Bharata and Aristotle to neuroscience. This is where the books section meets philosophy and psychology.

BOK-20 Literary theory: the big ideas

Before you start — BOK-20. Literary theory asks: what is literature, how does meaning work, and whose voice is heard? India had a sophisticated theory of literature (alankara shastra) well before modern Europe. **See also:** MOV-18 Film theory, MUS (rasa in music).

☐ BOK-20.1 Indian poetics (kavya shastra)

☐ **Rasa theory** (Bharata's *Natyashastra*): art creates "flavours" of emotion; the eight rasas (love, laughter, compassion, anger, heroism, fear, disgust, wonder), with peace (shanta) added later as a ninth.

☐ **Alankara school** (Bhamaha, Dandin): beauty comes from figures of speech.

☐ **Riti school** (Vamana): "riti is the soul of poetry", style.

☐ **Dhvani theory** (Anandavardhana's *Dhvanyaloka*, 9th century; Abhinavagupta's commentary): the best poetry suggests more than it says.

☐ **Vakrokti** (Kuntaka): poetry as "crooked", striking speech.

☐ **Auchitya** (Kshemendra): propriety, fitness of every element.

☐ **Tamil poetics** (*Tolkappiyam*): the tinai landscapes that match each mood of love to a landscape, flower and season.

☐ BOK-20.2 Classical Western poetics

☐ **Plato**: poets imitate imitations and stir dangerous emotions.

☐ **Aristotle's* Poetics***: mimesis (imitation), plot as the soul of tragedy, catharsis (purging of pity and fear).

☐ **Horace**: poetry should "delight and instruct".

☐ **Longinus**: the sublime.

☐ BOK-20.3 Modern schools of criticism

☐ **Formalism and New Criticism** (early 20th century): close reading of the text itself; Russian formalists (Shklovsky's "defamiliarisation"), I. A. Richards, Cleanth Brooks.

☐ **Structuralism** (from Saussure): literature as a system of signs; Roland Barthes, Vladimir Propp's *Morphology of the Folktale* (1928; 31 functions of fairy tales).

☐ **Post-structuralism and deconstruction**: meaning is unstable; Derrida, Barthes's "The Death of the Author" (1967), Foucault.

☐ **Reader-response**: meaning made by readers; Wolfgang Iser, Stanley Fish.

☐ **Marxist criticism**: literature and class; Georg Lukács, Raymond Williams, Terry Eagleton.

☐ **Psychoanalytic criticism**: Freud, Jung's archetypes, Lacan.

☐ **Feminist criticism**: Virginia Woolf's *A Room of One's Own* (1929), Simone de Beauvoir, Elaine Showalter, Gilbert and Gubar's *The Madwoman in the Attic*.

☐ **Postcolonial theory**: Edward Said's *Orientalism* (1978), Homi K. Bhabha (hybridity), Gayatri Chakravorty Spivak ("Can the Subaltern Speak?", 1988), Ngũgĩ's *Decolonising the Mind*.

☐ **Dalit aesthetics**: Sharankumar Limbale's *Towards an Aesthetic of Dalit Literature* (2004): literature judged by its truth to lived experience and its call for liberation.

☐ **Ecocriticism**: literature and nature; Amitav Ghosh's *The Great Derangement* (2016) on why fiction ignores climate change.

☐ **Digital humanities**: studying literature with computers (distant reading, Franco Moretti).

☐ BOK-20.4 Myth and archetype

☐ **Comparative mythology**: Max Müller, James Frazer's *The Golden Bough*, Joseph Campbell's monomyth, Devdutt Pattanaik's popular retellings.

☐ **Archetypal characters**: the hero, the trickster (Tenali Raman, Birbal, Anansi), the wise old guide, the shadow.

BOK-21 Literature, mind and society

Before you start — BOK-21. What reading does to people, and what people do with books: the psychology and sociology of literature. Claims are given with their evidence, and debates are flagged. **See also:** MOV-19 Cinema, mind and society.

☐ BOK-21.1 The psychology of reading and stories

☐ **Narrative transportation**: being "lost in a book" (Green and Brock, 2000); transported readers change their beliefs more.

☐ **Theory of mind and empathy**: studies by Keith Oatley, Raymond Mar, and Kidd and Castano (2013) link literary fiction to understanding others; some replications found smaller effects, so the debate continues.

☐ **Bibliotherapy**: reading as a support for mental health; used in libraries and clinics.

☐ **Reading and children**: reading aloud builds vocabulary and attention; India's ASER reports measure children's reading levels every few years.

☐ **Flow and deep reading**: Csikszentmihalyi's "flow"; Maryanne Wolf's concern for attention in the digital age.

☐ BOK-21.2 Philosophy and literature

☐ **Why we read fiction**: the "paradox of fiction" (why we feel for people who do not exist); Indian answer through rasa and sadharanikarana (universalisation of emotion, Bhatta Nayaka).

☐ **Literature as moral education**: the Panchatantra was written to teach princes; Martha Nussbaum argues novels train moral imagination.

☐ **Existentialist literature**: Camus, Dostoevsky, Kafka on meaning and freedom.

☐ **The Upanishadic dialogue and Socratic dialogue**: philosophy written as conversation.

☐ BOK-21.3 Literature and society

☐ **Literature and freedom movements**: "Vande Mataram", Bharati, Tagore, Premchand's *Soz-e-Watan* (1907, seized by the British), Faiz in prison, Uncle Tom's Cabin and abolition.

☐ **Literature and social reform**: Jyotirao Phule's *Gulamgiri* (1873), Ambedkar's writings, Rokeya's *Sultana's Dream*, Dalit and feminist literatures.

☐ **Literacy and access**: who gets to read and write; women's education (Savitribai Phule); Kerala's library movement (P. N. Panicker, the Granthasala Sangham, 1945; National Reading Day on 19 June).

☐ **Books and nations**: national epics (*Shahnameh*), national poets, the role of print in building nations (Benedict Anderson's *Imagined Communities*, 1983).

☐ **Banned books and burnings**: Nazi book burnings (1933), Heinrich Heine's warning that "where they burn books, they will end up burning people".

PART 7 — REVIEWS AND VOICES

About this Part. Three kinds of pages. (1) **Critics' Corner**: the great book critics and reviewers. (2) **The critics said, I say**: what respected critics said about a book, summarised in my own words with links, then my view. (3) **My Review Desk**: my own reviews. I never copy a review; I quote a few words at most, with credit, and link to the original.

BOK-22 Critics' Corner: great critics and reviewers

☐ BOK-22.1 Critics of the world

☐ **Samuel Johnson** (*Lives of the Poets*), **Matthew Arnold** ("the best that has been thought and said"), **T. S. Eliot** ("Tradition and the Individual Talent"), **Virginia Woolf** (*The Common Reader*), **Edmund Wilson**, **Lionel Trilling**, **Harold Bloom** (*The Western Canon*, *The Anxiety of Influence*), **Susan Sontag** ("Against Interpretation"), **Michiko Kakutani** (*New York Times*), **James Wood** (*How Fiction Works*), **Terry Eagleton**.

☐ **Review publications**: *The Times Literary Supplement* (1902), *The New York Review of Books* (1963), *London Review of Books* (1979), *The Paris Review* (1953, famous author interviews).

☐ BOK-22.2 Critics and literary historians of India

☐ **Hindi**: Acharya Ramchandra Shukla (*Hindi Sahitya ka Itihas*, 1929, the foundational history), Hazari Prasad Dwivedi, Ram Vilas Sharma, Namvar Singh, Nagendra.

☐ **Other languages**: Kuttikrishna Marar and M. Leelavathy (Malayalam), Ka. Naa. Subramanyam (Tamil), Kirtinath Kurtkoti (Kannada), Buddhadeva Bose (Bengali), Gopichand Narang and Shamsur Rahman Faruqi (Urdu), Bhalchandra Nemade's "nativism" (Marathi).

☐ **In English**: K. R. Srinivasa Iyengar (*Indian Writing in English*), Meenakshi Mukherjee (*The Twice Born Fiction*), G. N. Devy (*After Amnesia*), Sisir Kumar Das (*A History of Indian Literature*), Aijaz Ahmad, Harish Trivedi.

☐ **Magazines and pages**: *Hans* (founded by Premchand, 1930), *Indian Literature* (Sahitya Akademi), *Biblio*, *The Book Review* (1976), *Open*, Scroll's books pages, *Hindwi* and *Rekhta* (online Hindi and Urdu archives).

☐ BOK-22.3 Ratings and reader communities

☐ **Goodreads** (2007, owned by Amazon since 2013), **StoryGraph**, Amazon reviews, **BookTok** (TikTok) and **Bookstagram**; one line on what star ratings measure, and why a popular book is not always a good one, or the reverse.

BOK-23 The critics said, I say (page template)

Each page follows the same order:

1. **The book in two lines**: title, author, year, language, translator, what it is about (no spoilers).
2. **What the critics said**: 3 to 5 named critics or reviews, each summarised in one or two lines in my own words, with links and dates.
3. **Where they agree and disagree**: one paragraph.
4. **What I say**: my own view and why (link to BOK-24).
5. **If you liked this, read next**: three linked books, plus any film adaptation (MOV-).

BOK-24 My Review Desk (Kritikesh's book-review template)

☐ **Header**: title (original and English), author, translator, year, language, genre, pages, publisher, edition read.

☐ **My one-line verdict** (the answer first).

☐ **What it is about** (no spoilers).

☐ **What worked for me**: story, characters, language, ideas, translation.

☐ **What did not**.

☐ **Rasa meter**: which emotions it served (the nine rasas).

☐ **Best lines**: up to two short quotations, credited.

☐ **Who should read it**: mood, age, reading level, patience needed.

☐ **My rating** on a clear five-point scale, with what each point means.

☐ **Spoiler zone** (folded).

☐ **Tags, read-next links and the film version** if any.

PART 8 — READING, LEARNING AND COMMUNITY

BOK-25 The reader's practical guide

☐ **BOK-25.1 How to build a reading habit**: 20 pages a day, carry a book, mix easy and hard books, reading challenges, keep a reading journal (the tracker at the end).

☐ **BOK-25.2 How to read closely**: five questions for any book (what is it saying, how does it say it, who is speaking, what is left out, what stays with me).

☐ **BOK-25.3 Starter reading lists**: 25 world classics; 25 Indian books across languages (in translation); 10 books for children; 10 non-fiction books that explain the world; 10 books of poetry (each linked to the registers).

☐ **BOK-25.4 Where to read legally for free**: public libraries, Project Gutenberg, Internet Archive's Open Library, National Digital Library of India, Rekhta (Urdu), Hindwi and Kavita Kosh (Hindi poetry), Sahitya Akademi e-books, StoryWeaver (Pratham Books, free children's books in many languages). Always dated.

☐ **BOK-25.5 Literature festivals and book fairs**: Jaipur Literature Festival (2006, often called the largest free literary festival), Kerala Literature Festival, Hay Festival (1988), Frankfurt Book Fair, New Delhi World Book Fair, Kolkata Book Fair (1976), Chennai Book Fair, Sahitya Akademi's Festival of Letters; check dates every year.

☐ **BOK-25.6 Book clubs and reading communities**: how to start one; online groups; library reading circles; school reading programmes.

☐ **BOK-25.7 Learning to write**: free courses, journals that accept new writers, competitions, how to submit to a publisher.

☐ **BOK-25.8 Reading well**: eye comfort, posture, choosing editions and translations, respecting authors by not sharing pirated PDFs.

☐ **BOK-25.9 Literary places to visit**: Shantiniketan (Tagore; UNESCO World Heritage 2023), Lamhi near Varanasi (Premchand's village), Shakespeare's Stratford-upon-Avon, Tolstoy's Yasnaya Polyana, Malgudi Museum (Karnataka), Ghalib ki Haveli (Delhi).

PART 9 — NAVIGATION: TAGS, LINKS AND THE SITE MAP

BOK-26 Tag dictionary

☐ **Language**: #sanskrit #tamil #hindi #urdu #bengali #marathi #kannada #telugu #malayalam #gujarati #punjabi #odia #assamese #rajasthani #english #chinese #japanese #persian #arabic #russian #french #german #spanish #portuguese and others.

☐ **Country and region**: #india #pakistan #bangladesh #srilanka #china #japan #korea #iran #egypt #nigeria #uk #usa #france #russia #latinamerica and so on.

☐ **Era**: #ancient #classical #medieval #bhakti #19thcentury #modern #contemporary, and decades #1900s to #2020s.

☐ **Form and genre**: every form and genre in BOK-06 to BOK-11 (#ghazal #haiku #novel #shortstory #memoir #mystery #scifi #fantasy #manga #childrens).

☐ **Movement**: every movement in BOK-13 (#chhayavad #progressive #dalitliterature #modernism #magicalrealism).

☐ **Award**: #nobel #booker #internationalbooker #jnanpith #sahityaakademi #pulitzer #goncourt #hugo.

☐ **Person**: one tag per profiled writer and translator.

☐ **Mood and rasa**: #comfortread #pageturner #tearjerker #mindbending #funny #shringara #hasya #karuna #raudra #veera #bhayanaka #bibhatsa #adbhuta #shanta.

☐ **Reader level**: #beginner #reader #bookworm.

BOK-27 Cross-links and the website site map

☐ **BOK-27.1 Cross-topic links**: Movies (adaptations: MOV), Music (lyrics, songs and poetry: MUS), Technology (printing, e-books, AI: TEC), Cooking (cookbooks and food writing: COK), Gardening (nature writing: GRD), Sports (sports writing: SPT), the craft indexes (pattern books: CRO, KNT, EMB, SEW), Curriculum Index (Literature and Language subjects) and Exam Guide (awards and authors questions).

☐ **BOK-27.2 Suggested web addresses**: /books/ (home, Gateway), /books/how-books-work/<leaf>/ (intro twig), /books/literatures/<country>/<language>/ , /books/literatures/<language>/books/<era>/ , /books/forms/<form>/ , /books/genres/<genre>/ , /books/history/<era>/ , /books/movements/<movement>/ , /books/awards/<award>/ , /books/authors/<name>/ , /books/craft/<topic>/ , /books/ideas/<topic>/ , /books/reviews/critics/ , /books/reviews/<book>/ , /books/guide/<topic>/ .

☐ **BOK-27.3 Search phrases to own**: "first book ever written", "first Indian novel", "Jnanpith award winners list", "Sahitya Akademi award 2025 list", "Nobel prize in literature 2026", "difference between ghazal and nazm", "types of poetry with examples", "types of literature", "Bhakti movement poets", "how to build a reading habit", "best Hindi novels", "International Booker 2026 winner", with Hindi lines for Indian searchers ("hindi ka pehla upanyas kaun sa hai", "jnanpith puraskar 2025 kise mila").

PART 10 — SOURCES, CREDITS AND EDITOR'S NOTES

BOK-S Sources and credits

Knowledge belongs to the people who made it. These are the sources this index stands on; every page on the website will cite its own.

☐ **Reference works**: Encyclopaedia Britannica (literature, author and history-of-the-book entries); Sahitya Akademi, *Encyclopaedia of Indian Literature* (ed. Amaresh Datta and Mohan Lal, 6 volumes, 1987–1994); Sisir Kumar Das, *A History of Indian Literature*; Ramchandra Shukla, *Hindi Sahitya ka Itihas*; Sheldon Pollock (ed.), *Literary Cultures in History: Reconstructions from South Asia* (2003); A. K. Ramanujan, *Folktales from India* and *Poems of Love and War*; Martin Puchner, *The Written World* (2017); Irene Vallejo, *Papyrus* (2019); The Norton Anthology of World Literature; M. H. Abrams, *A Glossary of Literary Terms*.

☐ **History of writing and printing**: British Library (Diamond Sutra), UNESCO Memory of the World register (Rig Veda manuscripts, Jikji, Ramcharitmanas manuscripts), National Mission for Manuscripts (namami.gov.in), Graham Shaw's studies of early printing in India.

☐ **Reading and the brain**: Stanislas Dehaene, *Reading in the Brain* (2009); Maryanne Wolf, *Proust and the Squid* (2007) and *Reader, Come Home* (2018); Keith Oatley, *Such Stuff as Dreams* (2011); Kidd and Castano, *Science* (2013).

☐ **Official prize sources**: nobelprize.org (2025 and 2026 announcements); thebookerprizes.com (Booker 2026 shortlist; International Booker 2026); Sahitya Akademi (sahitya-akademi.gov.in); Bharatiya Jnanpith; K. K. Birla Foundation; pulitzer.org; IBBY (Hans Christian Andersen Award); thehugoawards.org; Académie Goncourt; Women's Prize Trust.

☐ **News reports used to check 2025–2026 results**: Devdiscourse and nobelprize.org (Nobel 2026, Anne Carson); KPBS/NPR, Euronews and Irish Examiner (International Booker 2026); Lit Hub (Booker 2026 shortlist; Pulitzer 2026); IANS and Tribune India (60th Jnanpith, Vairamuthu); Outlook India and Manorama Yearbook (Sahitya Akademi Awards 2025); All India Radio News (Saraswati Samman 2025); Books+Publishing (Hans Christian Andersen 2026); Book Riot and Lit Hub (Hugo 2026); Euronews (Goncourt 2025); Irish Examiner (Women's Prize 2026).

☐ **Data**: UNESCO *Index Translationum*; Wycliffe Global Alliance (Bible translation statistics); Guinness World Records; Census of India (literacy); ASER reports.

BOK-E Editor's notes (corrections and decisions on the brief)

1. **"Every book" is not possible in one booklet**: more than a hundred million books have been published. The booklet gives a sourced landmark register per region and a clear plan ("How the registers grow", BOK-05.6) to fill year-wise lists on the website.
2. **Indian literature is many literatures**: the brief asked for India in depth, so every Eighth Schedule language has its own entry, plus Rajasthani, Bhojpuri, Awadhi, Braj, tribal literatures and Indian English. Smaller languages are thinner here and will grow.
3. **Classical languages updated**: the five languages added in October 2024 (Marathi, Pali, Prakrit, Assamese, Bengali) are included.
4. **Sales figures** are labelled as estimates; many "best-seller" numbers in popular lists cannot be verified.
5. **Sacred texts** are listed respectfully as literature and heritage, without ranking faiths.
6. **Latest winners** were checked on 3 November 2026. The 2026 Booker Prize is due on 9 November 2026 and will be added after the announcement. The latest Neustadt and JCB results were not verified, and the entries say so.
7. **Reviews**: critics are summarised in my own words with links; never copied.
8. **Added beyond the brief**: the material history of the book, scripts of India, literary movements of India and the world, translators as authors, the craft of writing, publishing and libraries, copyright and AI, the psychology of reading, literary places to visit, a tag dictionary and a site map with search phrases.

BOK-T My Reading Tracker

Use the ☐ boxes across the booklet to tick what you have read or explored. A simple tracker for each Part: Part · Sections · Explored · Date started · Date finished.

Progress tracker

Part	Sections	Explored ☐	Started	Finished
PART 0 — THE INTRODUCTION TWIG: HOW CAN MARKS ON A PAGE PUT ANOTHER MIND INSIDE YOURS?	11			
PART 1 — LITERATURES OF THE WORLD	5			
PART 2 — KINDS OF LITERATURE: FORMS AND GENRES	6			
PART 3 — HISTORY: THE STORY OF THE BOOK AND OF LITERATURE	3			
PART 4 — AWARDS, PRIZES AND RECORDS	3			
PART 5 — THE CRAFT AND THE BUSINESS OF BOOKS	2			
PART 6 — IDEAS: THEORY, PHILOSOPHY, PSYCHOLOGY AND SOCIETY	2			
PART 7 — REVIEWS AND VOICES	3			
PART 8 — READING, LEARNING AND COMMUNITY	1			
PART 9 — NAVIGATION: TAGS, LINKS AND THE SITE MAP	2			
PART 10 — SOURCES, CREDITS AND EDITOR'S NOTES	3			